

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707-1740s) - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707-1740s)	
REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC CONCEPT FIRST	
01 MEANING, SCOPE AND GOVERNING THESIS "Disintegration" is accurate for the imperial command structure but	02 EVIDENCE BASE AND SOURCE CRITICISM (METHOD) Convert every major claim into claim - named evidence -
03 IMPERIAL STRUCTURE INHERITED IN 1707 Mansabdars held numerical ranks and owed service; many were paid	04 LATE-AURANGZEB STRAINS: BALANCED ASSESSMENT Conflict with Marathas after Jangnah Singh's death and difficulties with
05 SUCCESSION AND COURT CHRONOLOGY, 1707-1713 Technically, Succession and court chronology, 1707-1713 is analysed	06 FARUKHSIYAR, THE SAYYID BROTHERS AND KINGMAKER POLITICS, 1713-1720 The Sayyid ascendancy ended, but long-lasting had permanently
07 MUHAMMAD SHAH, NIZAM-UL-MULK AND THE SHRINKING CENTRE The subsequent "hunger" and stories of pleasure describe court culture	08 NOBILITY, FACTIONS AND THE POLITICS OF PATRONAGE Significance: Political division became military failure because no
09 JAGIRDARI AND MANSABDARI CRISIS: MECHANISM AND DEBATE Mansabdar and jagir were not separate problems; a rank without	10 AGRARIAN AND FISCAL STRESS: PEASANTS, ZAMINDARS AND REVENUE FARMERS Bihar Chauth was heavy demand; landlord and revenue farming to
11 DECCAN LEGACY AND THE MARATHA CHALLENGE Technically, Deccan legacy and the Maratha challenge is analysed by	12 JAT, SIKH, RAJPUT, BUNDELA AND ZAMINDAR ASSERTIONS Higher capture of strongholds did not erase the social-military
13 HYDERABAD, BENGAL AND AWADH: SUCCESSOR STATES His military and fiscal consolidation built a semi-autonomous state	14 REGIONAL MAP IN TEXT: A MULTI-CENTRED POLITICAL FIELD Awadh connected the middle Ganga plain to Delhi and the northwest;
15 MILITARY ORGANISATION, TECHNOLOGY, COMMAND AND LOGISTICS At Karnal, disputes over who should command and uncoordinated	16 TRADE, ECONOMY AND URBAN CENTRES: CONTRACTION WITH REGIONAL VITALITY Later conflict grew around the use and abuse of power and private
17 COURT AND CULTURE UNDER MUHAMMAD SHAH These works are material evidence for patronage and social world;	18 NADIR SHAH'S INVASION, KARNAL AND DELHI, 1738-1739 Karnal was the compressed battlefield expression of the wider crisis
19 WHY CENTRAL AUTHORITY DECLINED: MULTI-CAUSAL INTERACTION MODEL Fiscal stress weakened service; weak service reduced collection; lower	20 CONTINUITIES AFTER POLITICAL CONTRACTION They retained original forms because those forms remained
21 HISTORIOGRAPHY: DARK AGE, CRISIS OR REGIONAL TRANSITION? Delhi suffered catastrophic violence in 1739, and warfare burdened	22 TERMINOLOGY, TIMELINE, MEMORY HOOKS AND ANSWER TOOLKIT Technically, Terminology, timeline, memory hooks and answer toolkit

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707-1740s) - Learner-v2

Complete Learning Session

Subject: Modern Indian History | **Paper:** Prelims GS-I + GS-II analytical foundation | **Topic:** 01 | **Regenerated:** 13 August 2026 **Evidence key:** FACT = supported by a named source/event/institution; INTERPRETATION = evidence-led analytical position; LIMIT = what the evidence cannot establish; METHOD = source-use rule; BOUNDARY = context deliberately kept outside the core period. **Approval state:** generated, **approved=false**. Status remains yellow until the user explicitly approves all three deliverables.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

DEEP-REVIEW LEARNING CONTRACT

Control	Binding rule for this package
Syllabus boundary	Complete Modern History Core is taught chronologically and causally before optional enrichment.
Evidence method	Claim -> named Act/treaty/record/organisation/person/region or scholarly evidence -> analysis -> qualification.
Date discipline	Event, proposal, enactment, commencement, official policy, implementation and later interpretation remain distinct.
Historiography	Colonial, nationalist, Marxist, subaltern, Cambridge, feminist and other relevant arguments are attributed and tested, never used as labels alone.
Practice contract	Every solved item has demand decoding, an examiner-grade model, an executable answer/compression plan, marks rationale and answer-specific improvement.
Approval	This immutable successor remains approved : false pending explicit approval.

Canonical Basic/Core owner:

upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Modern-Indian-History\basic\01_Decline-of-the-Mughal-Empire.md

Canonical topic owner:

upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Modern-Indian-History\basic\01_Decline-of-the-Mughal-Empire.md

Optional Advanced owner: upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Modern-Indian-History\advanced\01_Decline-of-the-Mughal-Empire.md **Official syllabus mapping:**

upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Modern-Indian-History\OFFICIAL-UPSC-SYLLABUS-MAPPING.md

EVIDENCE, PYQ AND CURRENT-STATUS CONTROL

- **Official and primary evidence:** Acts, charters, treaties, proclamations, committee reports, proceedings, organisational resolutions, speeches and contemporary records are dated and read for authorship and purpose.
- **Regional and social evidence:** petitions, newspapers, memoirs, local studies and material geography qualify elite or all-India generalisation.
- **Economic and quantitative evidence:** revenue, trade, price, wage, craft and mortality claims retain unit, region, period and uncertainty; statistics are never invented.
- **Scholarly interpretation:** historian schools are competing explanations tied to named evidence, not memorised verdicts.

- **PYQ discipline:** repository ledgers and locally held official papers control wording and metadata; reconstructed wording and unavailable official keys remain explicitly labelled.
- **Current-status note, rechecked 2026-08-31:** The ASI and UNESCO Red Fort records are used only as a bounded material-heritage bridge for institutional and symbolic continuity. They do not establish the causes of Mughal political contraction or disputed numerical claims about the 1739 sack.

Live/primary context sources recorded by the predecessor generation:

- <https://asi.nic.in/pages/WorldHeritageRedFort>
- <https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/231/>



Refreshed teaching navigation

Distinct embedded teaching-navigation image. The separate continuous Cārvāka-style flowchart package remains an independent at-a-glance artifact.

Source audit and syllabus boundary

Markdown-first assembly uses the canonical package plus the paired Basic and Advanced owners. OCR sources are listed in the manifest for deeper checking; no live source is used except bounded heritage linkage. Verified local PYQs retain their provenance; unavailable keys remain labelled inferred, and no direct UPSC question is invented.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Verified/routed PYQs	3; two Prelims keys explicitly inferred, one verified adjacent GS-I Mains
Hard MCQs with explanations	48
Remedial MCQs with explanations	12
Original solved 10-mark Mains	3
Original solved 15-mark Mains	3
Original solved 20-mark Mains	3
Final register modules	15; placed last

Sources actually used

Source class	Exact source	Use and caveat
Repository knowledge	Modern History Topic 01 basic/advanced; README; Master Chronology; Revision Chart; PYQ routing; Answer-Worthiness Audit; bounded Topic 02.	Controls scope, chronology, answer architecture, successor-state comparison, terminology and existing answer-worthiness upgrades.
Repository bridge	Medieval History Topic 25 basic/advanced.	Supplies late-Aurangzeb, jagirdari, Sayyid, Maratha and eighteenth-century continuity; later Panipat material is kept outside the core.
Local OCR book	Bipan Chandra, <i>Modern India</i> , Chapter I and bounded Chapter II.	Foundation for ruler sequence, multi-causal decline, nobility, agrarian stress, Nadir Shah and successor states; older generalisations are qualified.
Local OCR book	Satish Chandra, <i>Medieval India: From Sultanat to the Mughals, Part II</i> , sections on Aurangzeb, northern India and the Marathas.	Detailed control for jagir debate, Sayyid policies, Nizam, regional states, Nadir diplomacy and the caution against overstating economic collapse.
Local OCR book	Sekhar Bandyopadhyay, <i>From Plassey to Partition</i> , Chapter 1.	Historiographical bridge between conventional decline and revisionist regionalisation; quantitative claims are not repeated as timeless facts.
Named primary traditions	Khafi Khan; Dargah Quli Khan; Mirza Mahdi Khan Astarabadi; farmans, sanads, letters, Company records and regional traditions.	Used through source-critical synthesis; no uncertain quotation, casualty total or invitation story is asserted.
Material/official heritage	ASI and UNESCO Red Fort pages; National Museum manuscript collection; IGNCA/Rampur Mughal-Persian manuscript catalogue.	Bounded evidence for material continuity, the Peacock Throne setting, manuscript survival and conservation; no current-affairs item is forced.
Verified PYQ routing	Repository 2021 Prelims Q45/Q48 and 2022 GS-I Q2 route.	Questions are included; unavailable local official Prelims keys are marked inferred.

Bounded authoritative links

- Archaeological Survey of India, Red Fort: <https://asi.nic.in/pages/WorldHeritageRedFort>
- UNESCO World Heritage Centre, Red Fort Complex: <https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/231/>
- National Museum, manuscript collection: <https://www.nationalmuseumindia.gov.in/en/collections/index/11>
- IGNCA, *Mughal and Persian Paintings and Illustrated Manuscripts*: https://ignca.gov.in/divisionss/kalakosa/kalasa_malocana/mughal-and-persian-paintings-and-illustrated-manuscripts/

No current-affairs item was forced. Qdrant was not used because repository Markdown, OCR-searchable local books and bounded official heritage sources were sufficient.

PART I - COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

REGISTER 01 - Scope and key terms

- Core window: 1707-1740s; late-Aurangzeb background only where causal; post-1748 developments only as bounded consequence.
- Decline = loss of enforceable central fiscal-military authority.
- Decentralisation = powers and revenues move from Delhi to provinces/localities.
- Regionalisation = local elite, military, zamindari, banking and cultural networks become durable political orders.
- Transition = Mughal forms survive while the location and social basis of force changes.
- One-line thesis: central command declined faster than Mughal legitimacy and institutions.

REGISTER 02 - Sources and evidence discipline

- Khafi Khan, *Muntakhab al-Lubab*: court and noble politics; elite/moralising limit.

- Dargah Quli Khan, *Muraqqa-i Delhi*: Muhammad Shah's urban-cultural Delhi; Delhi-centred limit.
- Mirza Mahdi Khan Astarabadi, *Tarikh-i Jahangusha-yi Nadiri*: Nadir's campaign; triumphalist patronage limit.
- Farmans/sanads: 1717 Company privilege; 1718-19 Maratha settlement; claim is not implementation.
- Company records: precise trade disputes; commercial bias and inland limits.
- Coins/khutba/seals/architecture: symbolic legitimacy and patronage; not direct territorial control.
- Never fix legendary army, plunder or casualty numbers without source qualification.

REGISTER 03 - Structural inheritance in 1707

- Emperor allocated mansab, jagir, title and office.
- Jagir = transferable revenue assignment; khalisa = crown revenue.
- Jama = assessed; hasil = realised; gap = fiscal credibility problem.
- Administrative order: village -> pargana -> sarkar -> subah.
- Subahdar and diwan were intended executive/revenue checks.
- Zamindars combined local rights, knowledge, forts and armed following.
- Strength: flexible imperial network. Vulnerability: delegated office could become hereditary power.

REGISTER 04 - Succession and court chronology

- 1707 Jajau: Bahadur Shah defeats Azam.
- 1709 Kam Bakhsh defeated.
- Bahadur Shah: able conciliator; partial Maratha settlement; Sikh campaign; finances worsen.
- 1712 Jahandar Shah/Zulfiqar Khan: strong-wazir experiment, conciliation, ijara risk.
- 1713 Farrukhsiyar installed by Sayyids.
- 1719 Farrukhsiyar deposed; Rafi-ud-Darajat, Shah Jahan II, Muhammad Shah.
- 1720 Sayyids overthrown; monarchy restored in form, not repaired in capacity.

REGISTER 05 - Nobility and the Sayyid Brothers

- Faction labels: Turani, Irani, Afghan, Hindustani/Baraha, Deccani; fluid coalitions.
- Competition: wizarat, mir bakhshi, governorship, jagir, seal and access.
- Sayyids: Abdullah Khan + Husain Ali; kingmakers, not emperors.
- Policies: jizya/pilgrim-tax abolition, Rajput/Jat accommodation, Maratha settlement.
- Structural symptom: emperor already depended on armed coalitions.
- Accelerant: deposition/killing of Farrukhsiyar damaged dynastic awe.
- Best verdict: capable administrators trapped in and deepening factional politics.

REGISTER 06 - Jagirdari and fiscal debate

- Be-jagiri = inadequate/delayed suitable assignment.
- Mechanism: more claims -> competition for productive jagirs -> short extraction -> rural resistance -> less remittance -> fewer troops.
- Frequent transfer prevented entrenchment but discouraged improvement.
- Khalisa grants placated nobles but weakened central cash.
- Ijara inserted revenue farmers with profit-driven extraction.
- Satish Chandra: structural jagirdari crisis.
- Irfan Habib: agrarian crisis and peasant/zamindar resistance.
- Richards: allocation and Deccan khalisa complicate real-versus-artificial shortage.
- Regionalists: resources also shifted into expanding local networks.

REGISTER 07 - Regional assertions

- Jats: Churaman, Agra-Mathura, fortified zamindari and peasant base.
- Sikhs: Banda Bahadur, Lohgarh, Punjab mobilisation; misls are later.

- Rajputs: Jai Singh/Ajit Singh combined mansab and regional demands; no single bloc.
- Bundelas: Chhatrasal; accommodation and assertion.
- Zamindars: intermediary, armed local leader and potential ruler.
- Rule: identity mattered, but land, revenue, forts, leadership and opportunity made resistance durable.

REGISTER 08 - Marathas and Deccan

- Late Aurangzeb: mobile resistance survives fort campaigns.
- Shahu versus Tarabai complicates Mughal bargaining.
- Bahadur Shah: sardeshmukhi concession, no full chauth settlement.
- 1718-19: swarajya + chauth/sardeshmukhi recognition linked to Sayyid alliance.
- Chauth approximately quarter claim; sardeshmukhi additional ten-per-cent claim.
- Baji Rao from 1720: offensive reach into Malwa/Gujarat/north.
- Maratha-Mughal relations included war, service, negotiation and factional alliance.

REGISTER 09 - Successor states

- Formula: provincial office + regional army/resources + zamindar/finance coalition + nominal Mughal sanction.
- Bengal: Murshid Quli Khan, 1717; survey, big zamindars, bankers, dynastic succession.
- Awadh: Saadat Khan, 1722; local chiefs, middle-Ganga base, continuing court ambition.
- Hyderabad: Nizam-ul-Mulk, 1724; Deccan force, war/treaty autonomy, coins/khutba continuity.
- Continuity in form, autonomy in substance.
- Not identical: Bengal commercial-fiscal; Awadh strategic agrarian; Hyderabad contested Deccan.

REGISTER 10 - Military and economy

- Army = noble contingents + artillery + cavalry + infantry + allies.
- Paper mansab did not equal deployable force.
- Core military problems: arrears, incomplete contingents, divided command, logistics and frontier response.
- Nadir's edge: unified command, mobility, fire discipline and flexible artillery; not firearm monopoly.
- Economy: imperial remittance declined while regional treasuries and markets could grow.
- Bengal trade, Indian bankers and merchants show vitality.
- 1717 Company farman = commercial privilege, not sovereignty.
- Delhi recovered after 1739; reject immediate all-India economic collapse.

REGISTER 11 - Nadir Shah, 1739

- Motives: Persian war finance + Indian wealth + Mughal frontier weakness; refugee dispute as pretext.
- Route: Qandahar -> Kabul -> Peshawar -> Lahore -> Karnal -> Delhi.
- Karnal: 24 February 1739; divided Mughal command versus integrated Persian force.
- Delhi: massacre after violence against Persian soldiers; casualty totals disputed.
- Took treasury, Peacock Throne and Koh-i-Noor; territories west of Indus ceded.
- Did not establish Persian rule over Delhi/Ganga plain.
- Effects: prestige collapse, frontier opening, fiscal shock, regional encouragement.
- Caveat: decline and autonomy predated 1739; economy and legitimacy persisted.

REGISTER 12 - Multi-causal interaction model

- Deccan overstretch raised cost and claimant pressure.
- Succession wars weakened arbitration and killed experienced personnel.
- Jagir/agrarian stress reduced revenue and troop maintenance.
- Factions converted scarcity into court warfare.
- Zamindars, Marathas, Jats and Sikhs reduced remittance and built alternatives.
- Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad retained provincial resources.

- Military-command weakness exposed frontier.
- Nadir accelerated timing and visibility.
- Ranking: structural core -> political transmission -> regional feedback -> external shock.

REGISTER 13 - Continuities

- Mughal dynasty and Timurid legitimacy survived.
- Coins and khutba retained emperor's name in successor states.
- Mansab, jagir, diwan, subah and Persian chancery vocabulary continued.
- Farman/sanad remained politically useful to Marathas and Company.
- Delhi remained symbolic; controlling imperial sanction mattered.
- Music, painting, manuscripts, architecture and Persianate etiquette continued and regionalised.
- Memory line: **form survived, force shifted.**

REGISTER 14 - Historiography and source limits

- Sarkar: Aurangzeb/personality/moral-political decline; valuable chronology, reduction risk.
- Satish Chandra: jagirdari-Deccan-administrative mechanism.
- Habib: agrarian extraction and resistance.
- Athar Ali: nobility and continuing imperial structure.
- Richards: policy and allocation qualification.
- Alam/Bayly: regional politics, commerce, credit and redistributed power.
- Best synthesis: central decline + regional transformation + uneven social costs.
- Always attach school to evidence; never list names decoratively.

REGISTER 15 - PYQ and answer spine

- 2021 Prelims: Arcot/Hyderabad, Mysore/Vijayanagara, Rohilkhand/Durrani; inferred key B, official local key unavailable.
- 2021 Prelims: pargana -> sarkar -> subah; inferred key A.
- 2022 GS-I Company armies: bounded later consequence; Company advantage was organisation-credit-revenue, not ethnicity.
- 10 marks: 2-3 named units + one qualification.
- 15 marks: 4-6 units + counter-evidence.
- 20 marks: 5-8 units + causal ranking + historiography/regional variation.
- Universal formula: define level -> claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit -> graded verdict.
- Final verdict: Mughal central authority declined; regional power and Mughal political culture continued in transformed form.

SESSION 1 - MEANING, SCOPE AND GOVERNING THESIS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Nadir Shah accelerated and advertised the crisis; he did not originate it. [THESIS] Aurangzeb's choices mattered, especially the long Deccan commitment and difficulties with Marathas and some Rajput houses, but neither personal blame nor communal causation can explain the subsequent politics of jagirs, zamindars, successor states and noble coalitions. [SCOPE] Background before 1707 is included only where it explains inherited structures and strains.

Technical definition: "Disintegration" is accurate for the imperial command structure but misleading if used to imply that administration, trade, urban life, culture or legitimacy vanished everywhere. [THESIS] The best explanation is interactive: unresolved succession + competitive nobility + jagirdari and agrarian pressures + Deccan over-extension + regional military-fiscal mobilisation + weak command adaptation + frontier exposure.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Nadir Shah accelerated and advertised the crisis; he did not originate it. [THESIS] Aurangzeb's choices mattered, especially the long Deccan commitment and difficulties with Marathas and some Rajput houses, but neither personal blame nor communal causation can explain the subsequent politics of jagirs, zamindars, successor states and noble coalitions. [SCOPE] Background before 1707 is included only where it explains inherited structures and strains.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Meaning**
- **scope**
- **governing thesis**
- **Decline**
- **Decentralisation**
- **Regionalisation**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Meaning; define scope, connect governing thesis with Decline to explain the mechanism, and use Decentralisation for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Compact scope visual

NECESSARY BACKGROUND		CORE ANALYTICAL WINDOW		BOUNDED CONSEQUENCE
late seventeenth century		1707 to the 1740s		after 1740
Deccan war, jagir pressure	->	succession, factions, regions	->	Durrani pressure and
agrarian and frontier strain		and Nadir Shah, 1739		later Company
opportunity				

The subject is the decline of imperial central authority, not the instant death of Mughal India.

Core teaching

- [FACT] The Mughal dynasty did not disappear in 1707. What contracted was the centre's capacity to appoint, transfer, tax, discipline and defend across the empire. Mughal emperors, titles, revenue vocabulary, coins, farmans and symbolic sovereignty survived far longer.
- [CONCEPT] **Decline** means loss of effective central fiscal-military authority. **Decentralisation** means power moving from Delhi to provinces and local intermediaries. **Regionalisation** means provincial, zamindari and military networks becoming durable political formations. **Eighteenth-century transition** combines central contraction with new regional orders.
- [LIMIT] "Disintegration" is accurate for the imperial command structure but misleading if used to imply that administration, trade, urban life, culture or legitimacy vanished everywhere.
- [THESIS] The best explanation is interactive: unresolved succession + competitive nobility + jagirdari and agrarian pressures + Deccan over-extension + regional military-fiscal mobilisation + weak command adaptation + frontier exposure. Nadir Shah accelerated and advertised the crisis; he did not originate it.
- [THESIS] Aurangzeb's choices mattered, especially the long Deccan commitment and difficulties with Marathas and some Rajput houses, but neither personal blame nor communal causation can explain the subsequent politics of jagirs, zamindars, successor states and noble coalitions.
- [SCOPE] Background before 1707 is included only where it explains inherited structures and strains. Developments after Muhammad Shah's death in 1748 are used only to show bounded consequences, not to turn this package into a survey of the whole eighteenth century.

Decline versus transition matrix

Analytical term	Correct use	Evidence	Unsafe overstatement
Decline	Loss of enforceable authority at the imperial centre	succession wars, provincial remittance failure, Karnal	"Everything in India declined"
Decentralisation	Delegated office and revenue moved toward provincial control	Bengal, Awadh, Hyderabad	"A complete political vacuum appeared"
Regionalisation	Local elites, financiers, zamindars and armies made new political arenas	Bengal revenue order, Awadh chiefs, Maratha networks	"All regions followed one identical path"
Transition	Old Mughal forms survived while the location and social basis of power changed	coin, khutba, mansab, Persian chancery, hereditary autonomy	"The old order ended in one event"

Exam-safe governing thesis

The Mughal crisis of 1707-1740s was a **decline of central imperial capacity inside a continuing Mughal political culture**. The centre lost resources and obedience faster than it lost legitimacy; provinces and armed regional groups appropriated imperial techniques; and the external shock of 1739 exposed a system already weakened by interacting fiscal, agrarian, military and political pressures.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - MEANING, SCOPE AND GOVERNING THESIS

START / CONCEPT: Meaning, scope and governing thesis

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Meaning · scope · governing thesis · Decline · Decentralisation · Regionalisation

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Mughal emperors, titles, revenue vocabulary, coins, farmans and symbolic sovereignty survived far longer. [CONCEPT] Decline means loss of effective central fiscal-military authority.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: "Disintegration" is accurate for the imperial command structure but misleading if used to imply that administration, trade, urban life, culture or legitimacy vanished everywhere. [THESIS] The best explanation is interactive: unresolved succession + competitive nobility + jagirdari and agrarian pressures + Deccan over-extension + regional military-fiscal mobilisation + weak command adaptation + frontier exposure.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Developments after Muhammad Shah's death in 1748 are used only to show bounded consequences, not to turn this package into a survey of the whole eighteenth century.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Nadir Shah accelerated and advertised the crisis; he did not originate it. [THESIS] Aurangzeb's choices mattered, especially the long Deccan commitment and difficulties with Marathas and some Rajput houses, but neither personal blame nor communal causation can explain the subsequent politics of jagirs, zamindars, successor states and noble coalitions. [SCOPE] Background before 1707 is included only where it explains inherited structures and strains.

SESSION 2 - EVIDENCE BASE AND SOURCE CRITICISM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Their continuation under a successor state proves retained Mughal legitimacy, not direct daily control from Delhi. [METHOD] Court chronicles are strongest on offices, noble alliances, ceremonial precedence and war.

Technical definition: [METHOD] Convert every major claim into: claim - named evidence - significance - limit. [METHOD] A farman or sanad reveals what an authority wanted recognised.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Their continuation under a successor state proves retained Mughal legitimacy, not direct daily control from Delhi. [METHOD] Court chronicles are strongest on offices, noble alliances, ceremonial precedence and war.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Evidence base
- source criticism
- claim - named evidence - significance - limit
- Persian court chronicles
- succession, offices, factions, jagirs, policy and court language
- Eyewitness and urban writing

How to use them: Frame the answer through Evidence base; define source criticism, connect claim - named evidence - significance - limit with Persian court chronicles to explain the mechanism, and use succession, offices, factions, jagirs, policy and court language for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Source matrix

Source family	Named examples	What it can establish	Genre or bias limit
Persian court chronicles	Khafi Khan, <i>Muntakhab al-Lubab</i> ; later court histories used by Satish Chandra	succession, offices, factions, jagirs, policy and court language	elite and moralising gaze; access and patronage shape emphasis
Eyewitness and urban writing	Dargah Quli Khan, <i>Muraqqa-i Dehli</i> ; Anand Ram Mukhlis's account of 1739	courtly culture, urban life, invasion experience and elite networks	Delhi-centred, selective and socially narrow
Persian conqueror's chronicle	Mirza Mahdi Khan Astarabadi, <i>Tarikh-i Jahangusha-yi Nadiri</i>	Nadir's campaigns, diplomacy and imperial self-presentation	triumphalist patronage text; numbers and motives need corroboration
Farmans, sanads and letters	Farrukhsiyar's 1717 Company farman; Maratha grants associated with the 1718-19 settlement; diplomatic correspondence with Nadir	legal claims, privileges, bargaining and intended hierarchy	an order proves a claim, not uniform implementation
Company records	English factory consultations, letters and commercial accounts from Bengal, Madras and Surat	trade privileges, remittances, urban markets and political risk	corporate and commercial bias; limited knowledge of inland society
Regional records	Maratha bakhars and correspondence; Rajput records; Sikh and Jat traditions	mobilisation, local political memory and regional claims	retrospective heroisation, lineage and sectarian framing
Material evidence	coins, seals, inscriptions, forts, palaces, tombs, urban fabric and the Red Fort	titulature, mint claim, patronage, continuity and spatial power	survival is selective; symbolic claim is not territorial control

Method rules

- [METHOD] Convert every major claim into: **claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit**.
- [METHOD] A farman or sanad reveals what an authority wanted recognised. It does not by itself prove that customs officials, zamindars or Maratha commanders obeyed it.
- [METHOD] Coinage and the khutba are strong evidence of symbolic hierarchy. Their continuation under a successor state proves retained Mughal legitimacy, not direct daily control from Delhi.
- [METHOD] Court chronicles are strongest on offices, noble alliances, ceremonial precedence and war. Their silence is weakest evidence for peasant welfare, women's work, artisan agency or village-level implementation.
- [METHOD] Company records are precise about goods, customs and corporate disputes but cannot be treated as neutral descriptions of Indian politics.
- [METHOD] Invasion narratives tend to magnify armies, booty and casualties. This package therefore avoids a fixed casualty total for Delhi and treats famous booty estimates as contested.
- [METHOD] Material continuity matters: the Red Fort's Diwan-i-Khas and its former Peacock Throne setting, surviving coins and late-Mughal painting show that cultural production and symbolic sovereignty outlived the centre's military reach.

Source-use flow

QUESTION
|
define the level: centre / province / locality / economy / culture
|
name the source: chronicle / farman / letter / coin / building / account
|
state what it proves
|
add genre, implementation, regional or numerical limit
|
give a graded verdict

UPSC traps

- A contemporary source is not automatically neutral.
- A later regional memory is not useless, but its political purpose must be stated.
- A coin in the emperor's name proves a legitimacy claim, not direct imperial taxation.
- A story about court luxury cannot substitute for evidence on jagirs, army payment or provincial remittance.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - EVIDENCE BASE AND SOURCE CRITICISM

START / CONCEPT: Evidence base and source criticism
|
v
EXACT TERMS: Evidence base · source criticism · claim - named evidence - significance - limit · Persian court chronicles · succession, offices, factions, jagirs, policy and court language · Eyewitness and urban writing
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: [METHOD] Convert every major claim into: claim - named evidence - significance - limit. [METHOD] A farman or sanad reveals what an authority wanted recognised.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that their continuation under a successor state proves retained Mughal legitimacy, not direct daily control...
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: A later regional memory is not useless, but its political purpose must be stated.
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Their continuation under a successor state proves retained Mughal legitimacy, not direct daily control from Delhi. [METHOD] Court chronicles are strongest on offices, noble alliances, ceremonial precedence and war.

SESSION 3 - IMPERIAL STRUCTURE INHERITED IN 1707

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Imperial structure inherited in 1707 comprises Khalisa, subah - sarkar - pargana - village and Timurid legitimacy as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Mansabdars held numerical ranks and owed service; many were paid through transferable revenue assignments called jagirs rather than ownership of land.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The system could govern diversity without uniform bureaucracy because it nested imperial authority within provincial and local intermediaries.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Imperial structure inherited in 1707
- Khalisa
- subah - sarkar - pargana - village
- Timurid legitimacy

- **dynasty arbitrated elite rank and succession**
- **repeated succession wars made arbitration itself a prize**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Imperial structure inherited in 1707; define Khalisa, connect subah - sarkar - pargana - village with Timurid legitimacy to explain the mechanism, and use dynasty arbitrated elite rank and succession for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Institutional map

EMPEROR

```
|-- mansab and office allocation
|-- jagir assignment / transfer
|-- khalisa revenue and imperial treasury
|-- farman, title, robe, seal and symbolic arbitration
|
```

SUBAH: subahdar (executive/military) + provincial diwan (revenue check)

|

SARKAR -> PARGANA -> village and revenue intermediaries

|

ZAMINDARS, qanungos, chaudhurs, cultivators, bankers and local armed followings

The system depended on circulation, audit, remittance and credible imperial arbitration.

Core teaching

- [FACT] The emperor stood at the apex of appointment and patronage. Mansabdars held numerical ranks and owed service; many were paid through transferable revenue assignments called jagirs rather than ownership of land.
- [FACT] **Khalisa** lands sent revenue more directly to the imperial treasury. Converting too much khalisa into jagir reduced the centre's cash flexibility, while withholding productive jagirs alienated nobles.
- [FACT] The official hierarchy ran broadly from **subah -> sarkar -> pargana -> village**. The 2021 Prelims hierarchy question tests this inherited scale.
- [FACT] A provincial subahdar exercised executive and military power, while the provincial diwan represented an intended fiscal check. In practice, strong governors could bring both political and revenue networks under personal control.
- [FACT] Zamindars were not merely tax collectors. They possessed local rights, forts, armed retainers, clan or caste connections and knowledge of cultivation; imperial administration required their cooperation.
- [FACT] The mansab-jagir mechanism was both a military establishment and a political contract. It tied a mobile nobility to the emperor so long as assignments were credible and service was enforceable.
- [ANALYSIS] The system could govern diversity without uniform bureaucracy because it nested imperial authority within provincial and local intermediaries. Its strength was flexibility; its danger was that office-holders could appropriate delegated power when transfers and sanctions lost credibility.

Inherited strength and vulnerability

Strength in 1707	Why it had worked	Vulnerability after 1707
Timurid legitimacy	dynasty arbitrated elite rank and succession	repeated succession wars made arbitration itself a prize
Transferable jagirs	prevented permanent local entrenchment	short tenure encouraged extraction; enforcement weakened
Composite nobility	drew talent from several regions and lineages	competition hardened when good assignments became scarce
Provincial delegation	extended rule over a vast empire	governors could convert office into hereditary autonomy
Gunpowder army	artillery, cavalry and fort war supported expansion	contingent shortfalls and divided command reduced effectiveness
Revenue depth	agrarian surplus financed court and army	high demand, jama-hasil gaps and rural resistance reduced remittance

Answer insight

Mughal decline was not the collapse of an institutionless court. It was the failure of a sophisticated but relationship-dependent system to reproduce obedience, revenue and military service after expansion slowed and central arbitration weakened.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - IMPERIAL STRUCTURE INHERITED IN 1707

START / CONCEPT: Imperial structure inherited in 1707

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Imperial structure inherited in 1707 · Khalisa · subah - sarkar - pargana - village · Timurid legitimacy · dynasty arbitrated elite rank and succession · repeated succession wars made arbitration itself a prize

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Mansabdars held numerical ranks and owed service; many were paid through transferable revenue assignments called jagirs rather than ownership of land.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Mughal decline was not the collapse of an institutionless court.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: It was the failure of a sophisticated but relationship-dependent system to reproduce obedience, revenue and military service after expansion slowed and central arbitration weakened.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The system could govern diversity without uniform bureaucracy because it nested imperial authority within provincial and local intermediaries.

SESSION 4 - LATE-AURANGZEB STRAINS: BALANCED ASSESSMENT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The long Deccan phase tied the emperor and large forces to southern warfare, added Bijapur and Golconda, and failed to extinguish mobile Maratha resistance.

Technical definition: Conflict with Marwar after Jaswant Singh's death and difficulties with other Rajput houses weakened an alliance that had supplied military and political support, although Rajput-Mughal cooperation was later renewed.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The long Deccan phase tied the emperor and large forces to southern warfare, added Bijapur and Golconda, and failed to extinguish mobile Maratha resistance.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Late-Aurangzeb strains
- balanced assessment
- Deccan
- prolonged war, fiscal strain and administrative absence
- Maratha resilience and Deccan political geography mattered independently
- Jagirs

How to use them: Frame the answer through Late-Aurangzeb strains; define balanced assessment, connect Deccan with prolonged war, fiscal strain and administrative absence to explain the mechanism, and use Maratha resilience and Deccan political geography mattered independently for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Causal background

Deccan annexations and prolonged campaigning
+ unresolved Maratha resistance
+ incorporation of new Deccani and Maratha claimants
+ emperor's long absence from north India
+ Rajput, Jat, Satnami and Sikh tensions
|
v
more military cost + more claims on jagirs + weaker supervision
|
v
serious inheritance in 1707, but not an inevitable collapse

Core teaching

- [FACT] Aurangzeb left an empire still formidable in army, administration and prestige. Bipan Chandra explicitly notes that the system remained efficient enough in 1707 for recovery to be conceivable.
- [FACT] The long Deccan phase tied the emperor and large forces to southern warfare, added Bijapur and Golconda, and failed to extinguish mobile Maratha resistance.
- [ANALYSIS] Expansion widened obligations faster than reliable collection. New Deccani and Maratha entrants sought mansabs and jagirs, while contested territories did not always yield the assessed revenue on paper.
- [FACT] Conflict with Marwar after Jaswant Singh's death and difficulties with other Rajput houses weakened an alliance that had supplied military and political support, although Rajput-Mughal cooperation was later renewed.
- [FACT] Jat, Satnami and Sikh assertions involved local power and agrarian grievances as well as religious identities. Peasants and zamindars supplied the social base of several movements.
- [LIMIT] Religious measures, including the restoration of jizya, could alienate and symbolically narrow the imperial coalition. Yet later rulers and the Sayyids reversed such measures, while Hindu and Muslim elites repeatedly formed cross-religious alliances for power and revenue.
- [VERDICT] Aurangzeb's policies created or aggravated constraints; they do not alone explain why later nobles fought over the wizarat, why provincial governors built successor states, or why revenue assignments lost credibility.

Balanced responsibility table

Dimension	Aurangzeb-linked contribution	Qualification
Deccan	prolonged war, fiscal strain and administrative absence	Maratha resilience and Deccan political geography mattered independently
Jagirs	more entrants and assignments under wartime pressure	the crisis developed through later grants, transfers, corruption and remittance failure
Rajputs	Marwar conflict weakened an older alliance	many Rajput nobles later returned to high office
Religion	jizya and temple actions harmed coalition-building in places	political and class interests cannot be reduced to Hindu-Muslim blocs
Frontier	northwest received less attention during southern concentration	post-1707 courts also failed to rebuild diplomacy and defence

Memory hook

AURANGZEB = accelerator and inheritor of strain, not a communal single-cause explanation and not a complete answer.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - LATE-AURANGZEB STRAINS: BALANCED ASSESSMENT

START / CONCEPT: Late-Aurangzeb strains: balanced assessment

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Late-Aurangzeb strains · balanced assessment · Deccan · prolonged war, fiscal strain and administrative absence · Maratha resilience and Deccan political geography mattered independently · Jagirs

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The operative mechanism is that the long Deccan phase tied the emperor and large forces to southern warfare, added...

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Conflict with Marwar after Jaswant Singh's death and difficulties with other Rajput houses weakened an alliance that had supplied military and political support, although Rajput-Mughal cooperation was later renewed.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: religious measures, including the restoration of jizya, could alienate and symbolically narrow the imperial...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The long Deccan phase tied the emperor and large forces to southern warfare, added Bijapur and Golconda, and failed to extinguish mobile Maratha resistance.

SESSION 5 - SUCCESSION AND COURT CHRONOLOGY, 1707-1713

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Succession and court chronology, 1707-1713 comprises Succession, court chronology and sardeshmukhi as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Technically, Succession and court chronology, 1707-1713 is analysed by relating Succession to court chronology, then testing the relationship through sardeshmukhi and chauth.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Bahadur Shah shows that a capable ruler could slow decline but could not simultaneously solve succession, Sikh resistance, Maratha bargaining, Rajput interests and the fiscal cost of elite accommodation.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Succession
- court chronology

- **sardeshmukhi**
- **chauth**
- **ijara**
- **1707-1713**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Succession; define court chronology, connect sardeshmukhi with chauth to explain the mechanism, and use ijara for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Succession tree

Aurangzeb dies, 1707

- |
- +-- Muazzam -> Bahadur Shah I, victorious at Jajau
- +-- Azam Shah -> defeated and killed
- +-- Kam Bakhsh -> defeated in the Deccan, 1709

Bahadur Shah I dies, 1712

- |
- +-- Jahandar Shah, supported by Zulfiqar Khan
 - |
 - +-- defeated in 1713 by Farrukhsiyar backed by Abdullah Khan and Husain Ali, the Sayyid Brothers

Bahadur Shah I, 1707-1712

- [FACT] Bahadur Shah was experienced, learned and conciliatory, not a caricature of immediate incompetence. He attempted accommodation with Rajputs, Marathas, Bundelas and Jats while campaigning against Banda Bahadur's Sikh movement.
- [FACT] He recognised Maratha **sardeshmukhi** in the Deccan but did not fully settle **chauth** or the Shahu-Tarabai conflict. Conciliation without a stable enforcement formula left the Deccan unsettled.
- [FACT] Chhatrasal Bundela and Churaman Jat could be incorporated tactically; Banda's movement, however, remained a major Punjab challenge despite Mughal campaigning.
- [FACT] State finances worsened through promotions and jagir grants. Satish Chandra cites contemporary anxiety that armies required money that was no longer readily visible.
- [ANALYSIS] Bahadur Shah shows that a capable ruler could slow decline but could not simultaneously solve succession, Sikh resistance, Maratha bargaining, Rajput interests and the fiscal cost of elite accommodation.

Jahandar Shah and Zulfiqar Khan, 1712-1713

- [FACT] Jahandar Shah's short reign depended heavily on the experienced wazir Zulfiqar Khan. The political problem was not simply royal frivolity; it was whether a powerful minister could govern without frightening emperor and rival nobles.
- [FACT] Zulfiqar pursued an inclusionist policy, abolished jizya, conciliated Rajputs, confirmed arrangements with Shahu and sought to restrain reckless jagir growth and enforce mansab contingents.
- [FACT] Revenue farming or **ijara** spread, transferring collection to contractors who promised a fixed sum and then pressed cultivators for profit.
- [ANALYSIS] A strong wazir offered administrative capacity but also created a coalition problem: the emperor feared replacement, old nobles feared exclusion and rivals organised alternative blocs.
- [FACT] Farrukhsiyar defeated Jahandar Shah in January 1713 with decisive Sayyid support. Throne-making now visibly depended on armed noble coalitions.

Chronology table

Date	Ruler or event	Analytical significance
1707	Jajau and Bahadur Shah's accession	succession consumed military and political capital
1709	defeat of Kam Bakhsh	last major phase of Aurangzeb's sons' contest
1710-12	Banda Bahadur challenge	Punjab resistance remained unresolved
1712	Bahadur Shah dies; Jahandar Shah succeeds	no institutional rule of succession
Jan 1713	Farrukhsiyar triumphs	Sayyid military-political leverage becomes decisive

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SUCCESSION AND COURT CHRONOLOGY, 1707-1713

START / CONCEPT: Succession and court chronology, 1707-1713

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Succession • court chronology • sardeshmukhi • chauth • ijara • 1707-1713

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Bahadur Shah was experienced, learned and conciliatory, not a caricature of immediate incompetence.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Chhatrasal Bundela and Churaman Jat could be incorporated tactically; Banda's movement, however, remained a major Punjab challenge despite Mughal campaigning.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The political problem was not simply royal frivolity; it was whether a powerful minister could govern without frightening emperor and rival nobles.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Bahadur Shah shows that a capable ruler could slow decline but could not simultaneously solve succession, Sikh resistance, Maratha bargaining, Rajput interests and the fiscal cost of elite accommodation.

SESSION 6 - FARRUKHSIYAR, THE SAYYID BROTHERS AND KINGMAKER POLITICS, 1713-1720

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Abdullah Khan and Husain Ali Baraha had raised Farrukhsiyar to the throne.

Technical definition: The Sayyid ascendancy ended, but kingmaking had permanently damaged the aura of unchallengeable monarchy.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

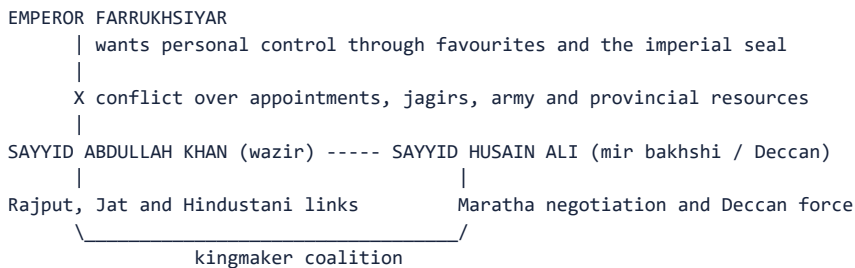
The Sayyid ascendancy ended, but kingmaking had permanently damaged the aura of unchallengeable monarchy.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Farrukhsiyar
- the Sayyid Brothers
- kingmaker politics
- emperors already needed noble military coalitions
- jagir scarcity encouraged blocs
- 1713-1720

How to use them: Frame the answer through Farrukhsiyar; define the Sayyid Brothers, connect kingmaker politics with emperors already needed noble military coalitions to explain the mechanism, and use jagir scarcity encouraged blocs for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Faction and office map



Core teaching

- [FACT] Abdullah Khan and Husain Ali Baraha had raised Farrukhsiyar to the throne. Their subsequent struggle was over the substance of sovereignty: who controlled appointments, the imperial seal, jagirs, the army and provincial resources.
- [FACT] The Sayyids pursued religious conciliation. Jizya and several pilgrim taxes were abolished; Rajput rulers received high ranks; Churaman Jat was accommodated; negotiation with Shahu produced Maratha grants.
- [FACT] In the 1718 settlement, formalised through imperial grants in 1719, Shahu's side gained recognition of swarajya and rights connected with chauth and sardeshmukhi in the Deccan in return for service and political support.
- [FACT] Farrukhsiyar's favourites attempted to bypass the wazir's office in appointments and seal business. Satish Chandra uses Khafi Khan to show the clash between an empowered ministry and personal royal rule.
- [FACT] The crisis aggravated jagir competition: court parties promised ranks and assignments to recruit armed followers, converting institutional scarcity into immediate factional mobilisation.
- [FACT] Farrukhsiyar was deposed and killed in 1719. Rafi-ud-Darajat and Shah Jahan II followed briefly before Muhammad Shah was installed. Counting Farrukhsiyar, four emperors occupied the throne during that calendar year.
- [FACT] Husain Ali was assassinated in 1720; Abdullah Khan's resistance was defeated. The Sayyid ascendancy ended, but kingmaking had permanently damaged the aura of unchallengeable monarchy.

Interpretation: symptom and agent

As symptom	As agent
emperors already needed noble military coalitions	deposition and killing of an emperor further reduced dynastic awe
jagir scarcity encouraged blocs	patronage promises intensified assignment competition
provincial resources mattered more than court title alone	Deccan and Maratha alliances shifted the balance at Delhi
composite politics continued	opponents weaponised race, religion and Timurid loyalty against them

Balanced verdict

The Sayyids were not merely villains who "destroyed" the empire. They attempted conciliation and administration under severe constraints, but their use of deposition and puppet succession made the emperor visibly dependent on armed patrons. They reveal how structural scarcity and personal distrust turned the court into a battlefield.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FARRUKHSIYAR, THE SAYYID BROTHERS AND KINGMAKER POLITICS, 1713-1720

START / CONCEPT: Farrukhsiyar, the Sayyid Brothers and kingmaker politics, 1713-1720

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Farrukhsiyar · the Sayyid Brothers · kingmaker politics · emperors already needed noble military coalitions · jagir scarcity encouraged blocs · 1713-1720

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Abdullah Khan and Husain Ali Baraha had raised Farrukhsiyar to the throne.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The Sayyids were not merely villains who "destroyed" the empire.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: They attempted conciliation and administration under severe constraints, but their use of deposition and puppet succession made the emperor visibly dependent on armed patrons.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The Sayyid ascendancy ended, but kingmaking had permanently damaged the aura of unchallengeable monarchy.

SESSION 7 - MUHAMMAD SHAH, NIZAM-UL-MULK AND THE SHRINKING CENTRE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Muhammad Shah, Nizam-ul-Mulk and the shrinking centre comprises Muhammad Shah, Nizam-ul-Mulk and the shrinking centre as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: The sobriquet "Rangila" and stories of pleasure describe court culture but do not explain the fiscal-military crisis.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The sobriquet "Rangila" and stories of pleasure describe court culture but do not explain the fiscal-military crisis.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Muhammad Shah
- Nizam-ul-Mulk
- the shrinking centre
- Nizam leaves the centre; provinces retain revenue
- appointments become factional and monetised
- late-Mughal painting develops intimate court and urban themes

How to use them: Frame the answer through Muhammad Shah; define Nizam-ul-Mulk, connect the shrinking centre with Nizam leaves the centre; provinces retain revenue to explain the mechanism, and use appointments become factional and monetised for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Political sequence

1719 Muhammad Shah installed
|
1720 Sayyid power broken
|
1722 Nizam-ul-Mulk becomes wazir and proposes restraint/reform
|
1723-24 court resistance + Maratha pressure + Deccan opportunity
|
1724 Nizam defeats Mubariz Khan and consolidates Hyderabad
|
1730s regional autonomy deepens while Delhi retains symbolic primacy

Core teaching

- [FACT] Muhammad Shah's reign, 1719-1748, brought chronological stability after rapid enthronements. Mughal prestige, artillery and administration still possessed recoverable strength in the early 1720s.
- [FACT] Nizam-ul-Mulk represented an able noble seeking to restore discipline: review jagirs, resume some khalisa, restrain revenue farming and reduce corrupt appointment practices.
- [LIMIT] His reform programme also protected old noble interests and included a proposed revival of jizya that contemporaries, including allied nobles, considered politically inopportune. Reform was itself factional.
- [FACT] Nizam left the wizarat, moved south and defeated Mubariz Khan at Shakar Kheda in 1724. Hyderabad thereafter exercised practical autonomy while retaining imperial forms.
- [ANALYSIS] Nizam's departure was not a formal declaration of independence. It was the conversion of high imperial office, Deccan networks and military capacity into a regional state.
- [FACT] Muhammad Shah's court continued to appoint, title and symbolically validate powerful nobles. Yet it lacked reliable cash, disciplined contingents and provincial obedience.
- [LIMIT] The sobriquet "Rangila" and stories of pleasure describe court culture but do not explain the fiscal-military crisis. A serious answer must distinguish patronage of music and painting from administrative failure.

Muhammad Shah: decline and cultural vitality

Political contraction	Cultural continuity and change
Nizam leaves the centre; provinces retain revenue	Delhi remains a major courtly and urban centre
appointments become factional and monetised	late-Mughal painting develops intimate court and urban themes
army pay and contingent enforcement weaken	khayal receives important court patronage associated with Sadarang
Nadir defeats the imperial host in 1739	Persianate etiquette, poetry, music and manuscript culture continue

Answer insight

Muhammad Shah's period embodies the central distinction of the topic: **the state at Delhi weakened, while the court and city remained culturally productive and symbolically consequential.**

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - MUHAMMAD SHAH, NIZAM-UL-MULK AND THE SHRINKING CENTRE

START / CONCEPT: Muhammad Shah, Nizam-ul-Mulk and the shrinking centre

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Muhammad Shah · Nizam-ul-Mulk · the shrinking centre · Nizam leaves the centre; provinces retain revenue · appointments become factional and monetised · late-Mughal painting develops intimate court and urban themes

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: It was the conversion of high imperial office, Deccan networks and military capacity into a regional state.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Nizam's departure was not a formal declaration of independence.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: A serious answer must distinguish patronage of music and painting from administrative failure.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The sobriquet "Rangila" and stories of pleasure describe court culture but do not explain the fiscal-military crisis.

SESSION 8 - NOBILITY, FACTIONS AND THE POLITICS OF PATRONAGE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Limit: Factions were produced partly by jagir and office scarcity, so they cannot be treated as an isolated moral cause.

Technical definition: Significance: Political division became military failure because no accepted authority could coordinate the host.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

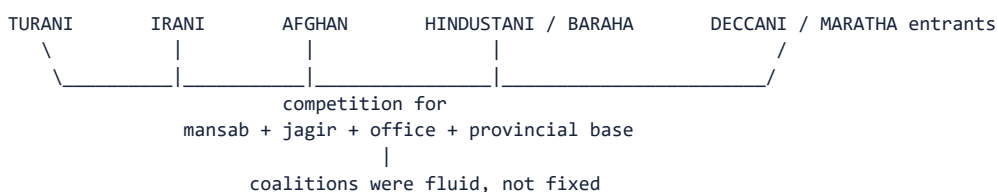
Limit: Factions were produced partly by jagir and office scarcity, so they cannot be treated as an isolated moral cause.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Nobility
- ions
- the politics of patronage
- Claim
- Significance
- Mughal nobles

How to use them: Frame the answer through Nobility; define ions, connect the politics of patronage with Claim to explain the mechanism, and use Significance for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Faction map



Core teaching

- [FACT] Mughal nobles are commonly described as Turani, Irani, Afghan, Hindustani and Deccani groupings. These labels indicate origin, kinship and recruitment networks; they were not permanent modern political parties.

- [FACT] Competition centred on the wizarat, mir bakhshi's office, provincial governorships, productive jagirs, access to the emperor and control of armed followers.
- [ANALYSIS] Ethnic vocabulary could organise trust, but coalitions crossed origin and religion when office required it. Nizam's anti-Sayyid coalition invoked Timurid monarchy, "old nobility" and religion together.
- [FACT] Able figures were abundant: Zulfiqar Khan, the Sayyids, Nizam-ul-Mulk, Saadat Khan, Murshid Quli Khan, Jai Singh and others. The problem was not an absolute disappearance of talent.
- [ANALYSIS] Bandyopadhyay uses this evidence against a simple "incompetent personalities" thesis: capable nobles invested their ability in regional power or factional survival because the imperial reward system no longer aligned private ambition with central service.
- [FACT] Mansabdars facing inadequate yields often failed to maintain their full sanctioned contingents. A nominally large rank therefore did not guarantee soldiers ready for battle.
- [LIMIT] Moral language about luxury and corruption appears frequently in chronicles. It is evidence of elite anxiety, but administrative mechanisms - assignment scarcity, arrears, sale of office and weak audit - explain more than private vice.

Claim-evidence-significance-limit example

- **Claim:** Factionalism weakened the empire.
- **Evidence:** Farrukhsiyar and the Sayyids competed over seal, appointment and Deccan resources; in 1739 leading nobles could not agree on command at Karnal.
- **Significance:** Political division became military failure because no accepted authority could coordinate the host.
- **Limit:** Factions were produced partly by jagir and office scarcity, so they cannot be treated as an isolated moral cause.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - NOBILITY, FACTIONS AND THE POLITICS OF PATRONAGE

START / CONCEPT: Nobility, factions and the politics of patronage

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Nobility · ions · the politics of patronage · Claim · Significance · Mughal nobles

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Significance: Political division became military failure because no accepted authority could coordinate the host.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Ethnic vocabulary could organise trust, but coalitions crossed origin and religion when office required it.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: These labels indicate origin, kinship and recruitment networks; they were not permanent modern political parties.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Limit: Factions were produced partly by jagir and office scarcity, so they cannot be treated as an isolated moral cause.

SESSION 9 - JAGIRDARI AND MANSABDARI CRISIS: MECHANISM AND DEBATE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The jagirdari crisis is strongest as a mechanism connecting elite competition, rural extraction and military underperformance.

Technical definition: Mansabdari and jagirdari were not separate problems: a rank without adequate assignment produced arrears; an assignment without audit weakened troops; a weakened army reduced collection.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mansabdari and jagirdari were not separate problems: a rank without adequate assignment produced arrears; an assignment without audit weakened troops; a weakened army reduced collection.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Jagirdari
- mansabdari crisis
- debate
- Mansab
- numerical rank and service status
- not itself ownership of land

How to use them: Frame the answer through Jagirdari; define mansabdari crisis, connect debate with Mansab to explain the mechanism, and use numerical rank and service status for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Jagirdari causal flow

expansion slows + wartime entrants and promotions increase
|
paper salary claims exceed dependable revenue assignments
|
be-jagiri / delayed assignment + competition for productive jagirs
|
short tenure and jama-hasil gap encourage rapid extraction
|
peasants and zamindars resist / remit less
|
nobles cut contingents; centre loses cash and coercive reach
|
factional court + hereditary provincial power

Terminology

Term	Meaning	Exam caution
Mansab	numerical rank and service status	not itself ownership of land
Jagir	assigned revenue claim used to meet salary/service obligations	transferable in principle; yields varied
Khalisa	revenue reserved more directly for the crown	shrinking khalisa weakened central cash
Jama	assessed revenue demand	paper assessment could exceed real collection
Hasil	revenue actually realised	jama-hasil gap reveals fiscal credibility problem
Be-jagiri	lack or delay of a suitable jagir for a claimant	structural scarcity, not a synonym for ordinary corruption
Ijara	revenue farming to a contractor	spread pressure and reduced direct administrative control

Satish Chandra's structural thesis

- [INTERPRETATION] Satish Chandra locates a central mechanism in the mismatch between a growing body of claimants and dependable revenue-yielding jagirs. Competition for assignments fed noble faction and short-term extraction.
- [FACT] Frequent transfer was designed to prevent local entrenchment, but it discouraged long-term improvement and encouraged a jagirdar to maximise collection before transfer.
- [FACT] Granting khalisa land as jagir could temporarily placate nobles while depriving the central treasury of cash needed for transport, artillery, salaries and frontier defence.
- [FACT] The crisis became visible in court programmes to review ranks, resume assignments, check promotion and prohibit farming of crown lands.

- [ANALYSIS] Mansabdari and jagirdari were not separate problems: a rank without adequate assignment produced arrears; an assignment without audit weakened troops; a weakened army reduced collection.

Debate and qualification

Interpretation	Core claim	Evidence used	Limitation
Satish Chandra	real structural shortage and low-yield assignments	be-jagiri, faction, transfers, depleted paibaqi	conditions varied by province and moment
Irfan Habib	agrarian crisis beneath elite fiscal crisis	heavy demand, peasant flight, zamindar-led resistance	resistance also arose from local opportunity and expansion
John F. Richards	parts of the crisis were policy-made; Deccan khalisa choices mattered	revenue existed but allocation and war finance distorted access	actual Deccan realisation and security remained uncertain
Revisionist regional view	resources did not simply vanish; they moved into regional networks	Bengal growth, bankers, revenue entrepreneurs, local agrarian expansion	regional vitality did not restore imperial coordination or protect all peasants

Verdict

The jagirdari crisis is strongest as a **mechanism connecting elite competition, rural extraction and military underperformance**. It should not be presented as a uniform quantified shortage across every province or as the only cause.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - JAGIRDARI AND MANSABDARI CRISIS: MECHANISM AND DEBATE

START / CONCEPT: Jagirdari and mansabdari crisis: mechanism and debate

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Jagirdari · mansabdari crisis · debate · Mansab · numerical rank and service status · not itself ownership of land

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The jagirdari crisis is strongest as a mechanism connecting elite competition, rural extraction and military underperformance.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Frequent transfer was designed to prevent local entrenchment, but it discouraged long-term improvement and encouraged a jagirdar to maximise collection before transfer.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Granting khalisa land as jagir could temporarily placate nobles while depriving the central treasury of cash needed for transport, artillery, salaries and frontier defence.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Mansabdari and jagirdari were not separate problems: a rank without adequate assignment produced arrears; an assignment without audit weakened troops; a weakened army reduced collection.

SESSION 10 - AGRARIAN AND FISCAL STRESS: PEASANTS, ZAMINDARS AND REVENUE FARMERS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Zamindars could withhold revenue, fortify positions and mobilise cultivators through locality, clan, caste or religious networks.

Technical definition: Bipan Chandra links heavy demand, transfer and revenue farming to peasant impoverishment, flight and uprisings associated with Satnamis, Jats and Sikhs.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

"Agrarian crisis" must therefore be spatially differentiated: extraction and insecurity were severe, but production and commercialisation did not collapse uniformly.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Agrarian
- fiscal stress
- peasants
- zamindars
- revenue farmers
- zamindars resist transfer or payment

How to use them: Frame the answer through Agrarian; define fiscal stress, connect peasants with zamindars to explain the mechanism, and use revenue farmers for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Rural power chain

imperial demand -> jagirdar / khalisa official / revenue farmer
|
zamindar and local staff
|
cultivator, artisan and village credit

If demand rose while tenure shortened:

extraction -> flight / concealment / arrears -> armed zamindar resistance -> lower remittance

Core teaching

- [FACT] Land revenue financed the imperial court and army. A weakening centre often responded by granting more assignments or demanding remittance, shifting pressure downward rather than solving the resource problem.
- [FACT] Ijara expanded in the early eighteenth century. Revenue farmers combined cash, local knowledge and coercive power; their profit depended on collecting above the contracted payment.
- [FACT] Bipan Chandra links heavy demand, transfer and revenue farming to peasant impoverishment, flight and uprisings associated with Satnamis, Jats and Sikhs.
- [FACT] Zamindars could withhold revenue, fortify positions and mobilise cultivators through locality, clan, caste or religious networks. They were both intermediaries of empire and possible leaders against it.
- [ANALYSIS] Peasant movements were not spontaneous class wars alone, nor merely religious rebellions. They often joined agrarian grievance to leadership by landed or warrior groups capable of sustained armed action.
- [REVISIONIST EVIDENCE] Bandyopadhyay notes that some regions experienced agricultural expansion, monetisation and stronger local lineages. New resources could empower regional actors even while the centre called their autonomy "rebellion".
- [LIMIT] "Agrarian crisis" must therefore be spatially differentiated: extraction and insecurity were severe, but production and commercialisation did not collapse uniformly.

Agrarian interpretation matrix

Observation	Decline reading	Regionalisation reading	Combined answer
zamindars resist transfer or payment	breakdown of imperial discipline	local rights and armed capacity strengthen	weakening centre converts intermediaries into rulers
revenue farmers rise	predatory extraction and administrative decay	cash-rich entrepreneurs enter politics	commercial power and coercion combine
peasant participation	subsistence pressure and oppression	local solidarity and leadership matter	grievance needs organisation to become durable revolt
new cultivation in some areas	contradicts universal economic collapse	expands regional resource base	growth can coexist with conflict and unequal extraction

UPSC trap

Do not write "the peasantry overthrew the Mughals." Rural resistance eroded collection and supplied regional movements, but leadership, weapons, forts, credit and political opportunity shaped outcomes.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - AGRARIAN AND FISCAL STRESS: PEASANTS, ZAMINDARS AND REVENUE FARMERS

START / CONCEPT: Agrarian and fiscal stress: peasants, zamindars and revenue farmers

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Agrarian · fiscal stress · peasants · zamindars · revenue farmers · zamindars resist transfer or payment

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Zamindars could withhold revenue, fortify positions and mobilise cultivators through locality, clan, caste or religious networks.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Peasant movements were not spontaneous class wars alone, nor merely religious rebellions.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: New resources could empower regional actors even while the centre called their autonomy "rebellion".

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: "Agrarian crisis" must therefore be spatially differentiated: extraction and insecurity were severe, but production and commercialisation did not collapse uniformly.

SESSION 11 - DECCAN LEGACY AND THE MARATHA CHALLENGE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: "Marathas versus Mughals" is too simple.

Technical definition: Technically, Deccan legacy and the Maratha challenge is analysed by relating Deccan legacy to the Maratha challenge, then testing the relationship through Chauth and Sardeshmukhi.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

"Marathas versus Mughals" is too simple.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Deccan legacy
- the Maratha challenge
- Chauth
- Sardeshmukhi
- additional claim conventionally represented as ten per cent
- asserted superior hereditary or regional fiscal right

How to use them: Frame the answer through Deccan legacy; define the Maratha challenge, connect Chauth with Sardeshmukhi to explain the mechanism, and use additional claim conventionally represented as ten per cent for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Chauth and sardeshmukhi

Claim	Working meaning	Political significance	Caution
Chauth	conventionally one-fourth of assessed revenue claimed from a territory	paid in return for recognition or restraint from Maratha exaction	not an ordinary village land tax and not always collected uniformly
Sardeshmukhi	additional claim conventionally represented as ten per cent	asserted superior hereditary or regional fiscal right	legal claim and realised collection could differ
Swarajya	core dominion associated with Shivaji's state	dynastic and territorial recognition for Shahu	contested by rival Maratha houses and local chiefs

Core teaching

- [FACT] Aurangzeb's campaigns did not destroy Maratha military capacity. Fort networks, mobile cavalry, local revenue knowledge and dispersed sardars allowed resistance to survive the fall of individual centres.
- [FACT] After 1707, Shahu and Tarabai represented rival Maratha legitimacies. Mughal policy attempted to manage this division rather than recognise one uncontested sovereign.
- [FACT] Bahadur Shah conceded sardeshmukhi but not a full settlement of chauth. Zulfiqar Khan and later the Sayyids moved further toward negotiated recognition.
- [FACT] The 1718-19 settlement associated with Husain Ali and Balaji Vishwanath linked Shahu's recognition and Deccan fiscal claims to military support for the Sayyids.
- [ANALYSIS] This was not simply Mughal surrender. It was an attempt to turn Maratha extraction into a regulated partnership; weak enforcement and competing commanders made the compromise unstable.
- [FACT] Under Baji Rao I from 1720, Maratha strategy shifted decisively toward Malwa, Gujarat and north Indian influence. Mobility allowed revenue claims to precede durable territorial administration.
- [LIMIT] "Marathas versus Mughals" is too simple. Maratha forces served Mughal factions; Maratha sardars competed among themselves; the Nizam bargained and fought with different Maratha interests.

Deccan interaction model

Mughal campaign cannot eliminate dispersed Maratha power
|
court offers fiscal recognition for service
|
Maratha chiefs gain legal and revenue leverage
|
Nizam builds Hyderabad while bargaining/fighting with Marathas
|
Deccan becomes a multi-centred political field, not a clean secession

Regional limit

Maratha expansion strained Mughal and successor-state finances, yet reach did not equal uniform rule. Collection rights depended on negotiation, military presence and the cooperation of local elites.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - DECCAN LEGACY AND THE MARATHA CHALLENGE

START / CONCEPT: Deccan legacy and the Maratha challenge
|
v
EXACT TERMS: Deccan legacy · the Maratha challenge · Chauth · Sardeshmukhi · additional claim
conventionally represented as ten per cent · asserted superior hereditary or regional fiscal right
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: It was an attempt to turn Maratha extraction into a regulated partnership;
weak enforcement and competing commanders made the compromise unstable.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: This was not simply Mughal surrender.
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: this was not simply Mughal surrender.
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: "Marathas versus Mughals" is too simple.

SESSION 12 - JAT, SIKH, RAJPUT, BUNDELA AND ZAMINDAR ASSERTIONS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: J-S-R-B-Z: Jats, Sikhs, Rajputs, Bundelas and Zamindars turned local rights into bargaining power; none alone replaced the empire.

Technical definition: Mughal capture of strongholds did not erase the social-military networks from which later Sikh power emerged.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

J-S-R-B-Z: Jats, Sikhs, Rajputs, Bundelas and Zamindars turned local rights into bargaining power; none alone replaced the empire.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Jat
- Sikh
- Rajput
- Bundela
- zamindar assertions
- Jats of Agra-Mathura

How to use them: Frame the answer through Jat; define Sikh, connect Rajput with Bundela to explain the mechanism, and use zamindar assertions for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Regional assertion table

Power or region	Named evidence within scope	Basis of assertion	Relation to Mughal order	Limit
Jats of Agra-Mathura	Churaman; fortified countryside and highway influence	zamindari, peasant support and local armed power	alternated between resistance, office and negotiated concession	later Bharatpur consolidation extends beyond the early window
Sikhs in Punjab	Banda Bahadur, Lohgarh and agrarian mobilisation	religious community, peasant support and armed organisation	Bahadur Shah first conciliated Guru Gobind Singh, then campaigned against Banda	misl and Ranjit Singh phases are later
Rajputs	Ajit Singh of Marwar, Jai Singh of Amber, Mewar diplomacy	dynastic states, mansabs and regional armies	high imperial office coexisted with demands for provincial control	Rajputs were not one united anti-Mughal bloc
Bundelas	Chhatrasal and Bundelkhand networks	local warrior-landed power	accommodation and autonomy could coexist	alliances changed with Mughal and Maratha pressure
Rohillas and Afghan chiefs	emerging Rohilkhand networks	military labour, settlement and local revenue	grew from weakened Mughal territories, not Durrani-created territory	major consolidation belongs partly to the later eighteenth century

Core teaching

- [FACT] Jat mobilisation around Agra-Mathura drew strength from fortified villages, zamindari authority and peasant participation. Churaman could be both negotiated with and treated as a rebel.
- [FACT] Banda Bahadur's movement challenged Mughal authority across parts of Punjab after Guru Gobind Singh's death. Mughal capture of strongholds did not erase the social-military networks from which later Sikh power emerged.
- [FACT] Jai Singh and Ajit Singh sought mansabs, governorships and regional concessions. Their politics demonstrates that autonomy often operated through imperial office rather than formal separation.

- [FACT] Chhatrasal Bundela built substantial regional power while entering shifting accommodations. His career resists a simple loyalist/rebel binary.
- [ANALYSIS] These movements weakened the centre by withholding revenue, demanding office, controlling forts and forcing military expenditure. They also created institutions and elites later absorbed into regional states.
- [LIMIT] Religious identity shaped solidarity, but political economy - land, revenue, fortification, office and armed labour - explains why mobilisation became durable.
- [LIMIT] They did not jointly fight for a nation-state. Alliances frequently crossed faith and regional lines, and each pursued its own territorial and fiscal interests.

Memory hook

J-S-R-B-Z: Jats, Sikhs, Rajputs, Bundelas and Zamindars turned local rights into bargaining power; none alone replaced the empire.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - JAT, SIKH, RAJPUT, BUNDELA AND ZAMINDAR ASSERTIONS

START / CONCEPT: Jat, Sikh, Rajput, Bundela and zamindar assertions

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Jat · Sikh · Rajput · Bundela · zamindar assertions · Jats of Agra-Mathura

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Their politics demonstrates that autonomy often operated through imperial office rather than formal separation.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Mughal capture of strongholds did not erase the social-military networks from which later Sikh power emerged.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Chhatrasal Bundela built substantial regional power while entering shifting accommodations.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: J-S-R-B-Z: Jats, Sikhs, Rajputs, Bundelas and Zamindars turned local rights into bargaining power; none alone replaced the empire.

SESSION 13 - HYDERABAD, BENGAL AND AWADH: SUCCESSOR STATES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Successor states were continuities in administrative form and transformations in the location of sovereignty.

Technical definition: His military and fiscal consolidation built a semi-autonomous state without renouncing Mughal sovereignty.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Successor states were continuities in administrative form and transformations in the location of sovereignty.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Hyderabad
- Bengal
- Awadh
- successor states
- Murshid Quli Khan; governorship confirmed 1717
- Persian administration, imperial titles, remittance and formal sanction

How to use them: Frame the answer through Hyderabad; define Bengal, connect Awadh with successor states to explain the mechanism, and use Murshid Quli Khan; governorship confirmed 1717 for the decisive comparison or

qualification.

Successor-state matrix

State	Foundational figure and date	Mughal continuity	Practical autonomy	Distinctive base
Bengal	Murshid Quli Khan; governorship confirmed 1717	Persian administration, imperial titles, remittance and formal sanction	appointments, revenue survey, transfer of jagirs, dynastic succession	rich agrarian-commercial zone; zamindars and bankers
Awadh	Saadat Khan Burhan-ul-Mulk appointed 1722	imperial governorship and continued court ambition	subdued chiefs, expanded subah and reduced effective financial dependence	middle Ganga revenue, local rajas and strategic location
Hyderabad	Nizam-ul-Mulk Asaf Jah; decisive consolidation 1724	coins, khutba, mansabs and nominal Mughal suzerainty	war, treaty, appointment and Deccan revenue controlled regionally	Deccan military aristocracy, revenue intermediaries and merchants

Bengal

- [FACT] Murshid Quli Khan moved from diwan to governor and built a tight revenue order. Survey, punctual payment and reliance on large zamindars increased the provincial state's extractive capacity.
- [FACT] Bankers and merchants became indispensable to remittance and credit. The Jagat Seth house later gained strategic importance in provincial finance and the mint.
- [FACT] Formal ties to Delhi continued, including remittance, yet dynastic succession and provincial appointments increasingly occurred without effective central direction.
- [LIMIT] Strong collection could mean regional stability and commercial confidence for elites while increasing pressure on smaller zamindars and cultivators.

Awadh

- [FACT] Saadat Khan received Awadh in 1722 and confronted local rajas and zamindars. His military and fiscal consolidation built a semi-autonomous state without renouncing Mughal sovereignty.
- [FACT] He continued to seek imperial office, showing that provincial and central ambition were complementary, not mutually exclusive.
- [FACT] Safdar Jung's succession was accepted through gifts and imperial confirmation after 1739-40, combining regional bargaining with Timurid legitimacy.
- [LIMIT] Awadh's later role as wazirate and buffer expands after the core period; this package stops at the formation logic.

Hyderabad

- [FACT] Nizam-ul-Mulk converted the Deccan viceroyalty and his own military following into a durable state after 1724.
- [FACT] Mughal institutions survived but changed content: some jagirs became more hereditary, revenue intermediaries gained latitude and regional patronage displaced transfer from Delhi.
- [FACT] Coins and khutba continued in the emperor's name. This was not empty theatre; Mughal sanction remained a political asset among nobles and neighbouring powers.
- [LIMIT] Hyderabad did not control the Deccan uncontested. Marathas, Mysore, the Carnatic and local chiefs constrained its reach.

Nature of successor states

MUGHAL PROVINCIAL OFFICE
+
regional military following
+
zamindar / banker / merchant support
+
declining transfer and audit from Delhi
=
HEREDITARY AUTONOMY WITH IMPERIAL LEGITIMACY

Verdict

Successor states were **continuities in administrative form and transformations in the location of sovereignty**. They did not produce a power vacuum; they produced a layered order in which Delhi remained the language of legitimacy but not the daily source of command.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - HYDERABAD, BENGAL AND AWADH: SUCCESSOR STATES

START / CONCEPT: Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh: successor states
|
v
EXACT TERMS: Hyderabad · Bengal · Awadh · successor states · Murshid Quli Khan; governorship confirmed 1717 · Persian administration, imperial titles, remittance and formal sanction
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Safdar Jung's succession was accepted through gifts and imperial confirmation after 1739-40, combining regional bargaining with Timurid legitimacy.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Strong collection could mean regional stability and commercial confidence for elites while increasing pressure on smaller zamindars and cultivators.
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: He continued to seek imperial office, showing that provincial and central ambition were complementary, not mutually exclusive.
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Successor states were continuities in administrative form and transformations in the location of sovereignty.

SESSION 14 - REGIONAL MAP IN TEXT: A MULTI-CENTRED POLITICAL FIELD

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Delhi retained titles, ceremonial authority and a strategic upper-Ganga core, but each corridor required cooperation from regional powers.

Technical definition: Awadh connected the middle Ganga plain to Delhi and the northwest; its rulers could be provincial governors, regional sovereigns and imperial office-seekers at once.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

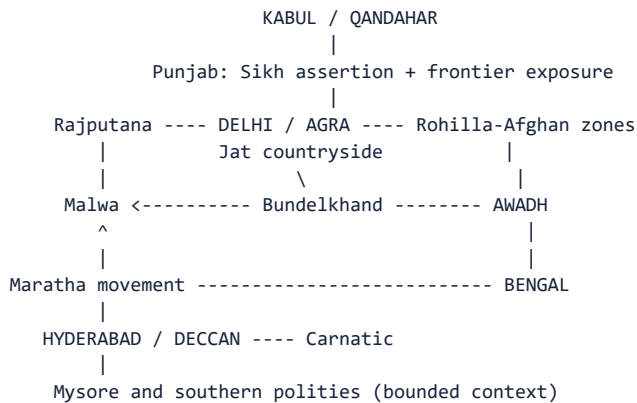
Delhi retained titles, ceremonial authority and a strategic upper-Ganga core, but each corridor required cooperation from regional powers.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Regional map in text
- a multi-centred political field
- Jat countryside
- Delhi
- Ganga
- Agra-Mathura

How to use them: Frame the answer through Regional map in text; define a multi-centred political field, connect Jat countryside with Delhi to explain the mechanism, and use Ganga for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Map



How to read the map

- Delhi retained titles, ceremonial authority and a strategic upper-Ganga core, but each corridor required cooperation from regional powers.
- Punjab combined imperial frontier defence, Sikh mobilisation and the route later used by Nadir Shah and Ahmad Shah Durrani.
- Agra-Mathura was not merely a road from Delhi; Jat fortification and zamindari power could disrupt communications.
- Malwa connected north India to the Deccan and became a major arena of Maratha expansion and Nizam-Maratha competition.
- Bengal's distance, revenue surplus and commercial networks made effective autonomy possible while symbolic Mughal links remained useful.
- Awadh connected the middle Ganga plain to Delhi and the northwest; its rulers could be provincial governors, regional sovereigns and imperial office-seekers at once.
- The map shows why "fragmentation" did not produce isolated boxes. Revenue, troops, bankers, pilgrims, merchants and diplomatic letters continued to move across political boundaries.

UPSC map use

In a Mains answer, draw a simple north-centre-east-Deccan arrow map to show that the crisis was spatial: frontier shock in the northwest, regional fiscal consolidation in the east, agrarian-zamindari assertion around the core and Maratha pressure from the Deccan.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - REGIONAL MAP IN TEXT: A MULTI-CENTRED POLITICAL FIELD

START / CONCEPT: Regional map in text: a multi-centred political field
 ↓
 EXACT TERMS: Regional map in text · a multi-centred political field · Jat countryside · Delhi · Ganga · Agra-Mathura
 ↓
 MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The map shows why "fragmentation" did not produce isolated boxes.
 ↓
 CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Agra-Mathura was not merely a road from Delhi; Jat fortification and zamindari power could disrupt communications.
 ↓
 UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Bengal's distance, revenue surplus and commercial networks made effective autonomy possible while symbolic Mughal links remained useful.
 ↓
 ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Delhi retained titles, ceremonial authority and a strategic upper-Ganga core, but each corridor required cooperation from regional powers.

SESSION 15 - MILITARY ORGANISATION, TECHNOLOGY, COMMAND AND LOGISTICS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Military "technological backwardness" is too broad for 1739.

Technical definition: At Karnal, disputes over who should command and uncoordinated action by leading nobles allowed defeat in detail.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Technology mattered, but organisation, pay, mobility, intelligence and coalition discipline determined whether technology could be used.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Military organisation
- technology
- command
- logistics
- fiscal-command crisis expressed on the battlefield
- Cavalry

How to use them: Frame the answer through Military organisation; define technology, connect command with logistics to explain the mechanism, and use fiscal-command crisis expressed on the battlefield for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Comparative military matrix

Dimension	Mughal strength inherited	Early eighteenth-century limit	Comparative implication
Cavalry	large mansab-based mounted establishment	paper ranks, arrears and incomplete contingents	numerical claims overstated field-ready force
Artillery	prestigious heavy guns and experienced gunners	slow movement and divided command	hardware without coordination could not decide battle
Infantry and firearms	musketeers and fort garrisons existed	no consistent integrated drill across noble contingents	avoid "Mughals had no guns" explanations
Command	emperor and great nobles could mobilise major hosts	precedence disputes and factional distrust	Karnal was an organisational as well as tactical defeat
Logistics	agrarian revenue, transport staff and road networks	cash shortage, forage and fragmented remittance	prolonged campaigning became harder
Frontier system	Kabul-Peshawar-Lahore chain, diplomacy and tribal subsidies	neglect, delayed intelligence and weak reinforcement	Nadir advanced before coherent defence formed

Core teaching

- [FACT] The Mughal army was not a single standing national army. Imperial forces combined household troops, noble contingents, artillery, infantry, local levies and allied rulers.
- [FACT] Mansabdars were required to maintain troops according to rank, but fiscal strain and weak inspection encouraged shortfalls.
- [ANALYSIS] Heavy artillery and large camps were not inherently obsolete; they became liabilities when command was divided, movement slow and battlefield initiative uncoordinated.
- [FACT] Nadir's force possessed an advantage in unified command, mobility, disciplined fire and flexible light artillery. The contrast was organisational integration, not a simple firearm/no-firearm divide.
- [FACT] At Karnal, disputes over who should command and uncoordinated action by leading nobles allowed defeat in detail. Khan-i-Dauran was mortally wounded; Saadat Khan and Nizam-ul-Mulk were captured or compelled into

submission.

- [LIMIT] Military "technological backwardness" is too broad for 1739. Mughal India had artillery, skilled metalwork and arms production; the problem was converting resources into a coherent, paid and responsive field force.
- [BOUNDARY] European companies were present as armed commercial corporations with fortified settlements and maritime support, but before the 1740s they were not yet the paramount explanation for Mughal decline.

Military-fiscal loop

```
unreliable jagir yield -> incomplete contingents -> weaker collection
      ^                               |
      |                               v
more arrears <- less remittance <- local resistance
```

Answer verdict

The military crisis was a **fiscal-command crisis expressed on the battlefield**. Technology mattered, but organisation, pay, mobility, intelligence and coalition discipline determined whether technology could be used.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - MILITARY ORGANISATION, TECHNOLOGY, COMMAND AND LOGISTICS

```
START / CONCEPT: Military organisation, technology, command and logistics
      |
      v
EXACT TERMS: Military organisation · technology · command · logistics · fiscal-command crisis
expressed on the battlefield · Cavalry
      |
      v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: At Karnal, disputes over who should command and uncoordinated action by
leading nobles allowed defeat in detail.
      |
      v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Heavy artillery and large camps were not inherently obsolete; they became
liabilities when command was divided, movement slow and battlefield initiative uncoordinated.
      |
      v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The Mughal army was not a single standing national army.
      |
      v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Technology mattered, but organisation, pay, mobility, intelligence and
coalition discipline determined whether technology could be used.
```

SESSION 16 - TRADE, ECONOMY AND URBAN CENTRES: CONTRACTION WITH REGIONAL VITALITY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The safest economic conclusion is uneven redistribution: some imperial circuits and war zones declined, while regional agrarian, banking, artisanal and commercial centres remained vigorous.

Technical definition: Later conflict grew around the use and abuse of passes and private trade; the farman was not a grant of territorial sovereignty.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The safest economic conclusion is uneven redistribution: some imperial circuits and war zones declined, while regional agrarian, banking, artisanal and commercial centres remained vigorous.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Trade
- economy
- urban centres
- contraction with regional vitality
- uneven redistribution

- warfare damaged routes and cultivation in contested zones

How to use them: Frame the answer through Trade; define economy, connect urban centres with contraction with regional vitality to explain the mechanism, and use uneven redistribution for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Economy balance sheet

Evidence of disruption	Evidence of continuity or vitality
warfare damaged routes and cultivation in contested zones	Bengal's agrarian and textile economy supported strong provincial finance
revenue farming and short-term extraction burdened cultivators	bankers and merchants financed remittance and regional courts
Delhi's treasury and northern circuits suffered in 1739	Satish Chandra notes Delhi remained a trade, craft and finance centre after the invasion
Deccan war harmed local production and transport	ports, inland markets and merchant networks continued across political boundaries
provincial remittance to Delhi declined	resources were often retained and reinvested regionally rather than disappearing

Core teaching

- [FACT] Mughal political integration had supported roads, markets, mints, urban demand and large craft industries. Central decline disturbed some of these circuits but did not erase them.
- [FACT] Bengal's revenue and commerce allowed Murshid Quli Khan's regime to combine strong collection with merchant-bankers and a growing provincial capital.
- [FACT] Indian merchants remained important in inland and maritime trade. Company records reveal commercial competition and negotiation, not an already complete European monopoly.
- [FACT] Farrukhsiyar's 1717 farman granted the English Company important Bengal trade privileges. Later conflict grew around the use and abuse of passes and private trade; the farman was not a grant of territorial sovereignty.
- [ANALYSIS] Less remittance to Delhi could appear as imperial fiscal decline while simultaneously strengthening regional courts, zamindars and financiers.
- [FACT] Nadir's invasion removed treasury wealth and disrupted Delhi, yet Satish Chandra warns that the economic effect of famous booty totals is often overstated; the city remained an important centre afterwards.
- [LIMIT] Revisionist vitality does not mean a regional golden age. War, exaction and credit dependence could enrich large intermediaries while exposing peasants, artisans and small traders to insecurity.

Company presence: bounded context

commercial privilege (1717 farman)
 |
 factories + private trade + fortified settlements
 |
 political bargaining with regional states
 |
 later military-fiscal expansion after the core period

Opportunity was created by a competitive multi-state field; conquest was not automatic in 1707.

Verdict

The safest economic conclusion is **uneven redistribution**: some imperial circuits and war zones declined, while regional agrarian, banking, artisanal and commercial centres remained vigorous.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - TRADE, ECONOMY AND URBAN CENTRES: CONTRACTION WITH REGIONAL VITALITY

START / CONCEPT: Trade, economy and urban centres: contraction with regional vitality

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Trade · economy · urban centres · contraction with regional vitality · uneven redistribution · warfare damaged routes and cultivation in contested zones

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Later conflict grew around the use and abuse of passes and private trade; the farman was not a grant of territorial sovereignty.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Revisionist vitality does not mean a regional golden age.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Less remittance to Delhi could appear as imperial fiscal decline while simultaneously strengthening regional courts, zamindars and financiers.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The safest economic conclusion is uneven redistribution: some imperial circuits and war zones declined, while regional agrarian, banking, artisanal and commercial centres remained vigorous.

SESSION 17 - COURT AND CULTURE UNDER MUHAMMAD SHAH

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Muhammad Shah's court is associated with important patronage of music, including the development of khayal through musicians such as Niyamat Khan "Sadarang".

Technical definition: These works are material evidence for patronage and social worlds, not proof of good government. [SOURCE] Dargah Quli Khan's Muraqqa-i Dehli depicts a lively city of nobles, performers, shrines and markets during the Muhammad Shah period.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Muhammad Shah's court is associated with important patronage of music, including the development of khayal through musicians such as Niyamat Khan "Sadarang".

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Court
- culture under Muhammad Shah
- music and painting patronage
- cultural production continued despite contraction
- pleasure caused imperial collapse
- urban chronicle

How to use them: Frame the answer through Court; define culture under Muhammad Shah, connect music and painting patronage with cultural production continued despite contraction to explain the mechanism, and use pleasure caused imperial collapse for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Culture-state distinction

weaker provincial obedience != absence of cultural production

court patronage -> music, painting, poetry, etiquette and manuscripts
urban networks -> performers, ateliers, merchants and connoisseurs
regional courts -> dispersal and adaptation of Mughal forms

Core teaching

- [FACT] Muhammad Shah's court is associated with important patronage of music, including the development of khayal through musicians such as Niyamat Khan "Sadarang".

- [FACT] Late-Mughal painting shifted toward intimate court scenes, portraits, festivals, leisure and urban life. These works are material evidence for patronage and social worlds, not proof of good government.
- [SOURCE] Dargah Quli Khan's *Muraqqa-i Dehli* depicts a lively city of nobles, performers, shrines and markets during the Muhammad Shah period.
- [FACT] Persian remained central to administration and elite literary culture, while regional courts and vernacular traditions expanded.
- [ANALYSIS] Provincial autonomy redistributed patronage. Artists, scribes, musicians and administrators could move to Awadh, Bengal, Hyderabad and other centres, carrying Mughal forms into regional idioms.
- [MATERIAL LINK] The Red Fort remained a powerful spatial symbol. ASI identifies the Diwan-i-Khas as the setting of the Peacock Throne later carried away by Nadir Shah; UNESCO treats the complex as a layered symbol of power and later political change.
- [LIMIT] The label "decadent court" converts aesthetic preference into a causal theory. Luxury may appear in moralising sources, but culture cannot explain jagir scarcity, rural resistance or frontier failure.

Evidence and inference

Evidence	Safe inference	Unsafe inference
music and painting patronage	cultural production continued despite contraction	pleasure caused imperial collapse
urban chronicle	Delhi retained social and commercial vitality	every social group prospered
regional spread of artists	patronage decentralised	Mughal culture disappeared from Delhi
Red Fort and throne memory	symbolic sovereignty remained legible	monumental splendour guaranteed military power

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - COURT AND CULTURE UNDER MUHAMMAD SHAH

START / CONCEPT: Court and culture under Muhammad Shah

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Court • culture under Muhammad Shah • music and painting patronage • cultural production continued despite contraction • pleasure caused imperial collapse • urban chronicle

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The label "decadent court" converts aesthetic preference into a causal theory.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: These works are material evidence for patronage and social worlds, not proof of good government. [SOURCE] Dargah Quli Khan's *Muraqqa-i Dehli* depicts a lively city of nobles, performers, shrines and markets during the Muhammad Shah period.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Luxury may appear in moralising sources, but culture cannot explain jagir scarcity, rural resistance or frontier failure.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Muhammad Shah's court is associated with important patronage of music, including the development of khayal through musicians such as Niyamat Khan "Sadarang".

SESSION 18 - NADIR SHAH'S INVASION, KARNAL AND DELHI, 1738-1739

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: After violence against Persian soldiers amid a rumour that Nadir had been killed, Nadir ordered a massacre. [DISCIPLINE] No fixed casualty number is used here because contemporary and later estimates vary widely and are shaped by the rhetoric of catastrophe.

Technical definition: Karnal was the compressed battlefield expression of the wider crisis: paper strength without coordination, noble precedence without common command and a frontier system without timely response.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Stories that Nizam-ul-Mulk or Saadat Khan invited Nadir lack documentary proof in Satish Chandra's assessment and should not be stated as fact.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Nadir Shah's invasion**
- **Karnal**
- **Delhi**
- **Prestige**
- **1738-1739**
- **24 February 1739**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Nadir Shah's invasion; define Karnal, connect Delhi with Prestige to explain the mechanism, and use 1738-1739 for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Campaign route

Safavid collapse and Nadir's rise
|
Qandahar captured, 1738
|
Kabul -> Peshawar -> Lahore
|
Karnal, 24 February 1739
|
Muhammad Shah submits; march to Delhi
|
violence, massacre and negotiated plunder
|
withdrawal with booty and territories west of the Indus

Why Nadir invaded

- [FACT] Nadir had rebuilt Persian power through prolonged war and required resources to sustain a large military establishment.
- [FACT] He cited Afghan fugitives and Mughal failure to seal the frontier in diplomatic exchanges. Satish Chandra treats these complaints as a pretext rather than a sufficient cause.
- [FACT] Qandahar, Kabul and the northwest gateway had lost effective Mughal reinforcement. Delhi failed to respond coherently to repeated embassies and warnings.
- [FACT] India's accumulated treasury wealth and visible political weakness made invasion attractive.
- [LIMIT] Stories that Nizam-ul-Mulk or Saadat Khan invited Nadir lack documentary proof in Satish Chandra's assessment and should not be stated as fact.

Karnal

- [FACT] The conventional modern date of the battle is **24 February 1739**. The Mughal camp included Muhammad Shah, Nizam-ul-Mulk, Saadat Khan and Khan-i-Dauran.
- [FACT] Mughal nobles disagreed over command and plan. Saadat Khan engaged without an integrated strategy; Khan-i-Dauran moved to support him and was mortally wounded.
- [FACT] Nadir's unified command, mobile firepower and tactical control defeated a larger but fragmented imperial host.
- [ANALYSIS] Karnal was the compressed battlefield expression of the wider crisis: paper strength without coordination, noble precedence without common command and a frontier system without timely response.
- [LIMIT] Avoid legendary army totals and claims that the battle alone destroyed the empire.

Delhi

- [FACT] Muhammad Shah submitted and accompanied Nadir to Delhi. After violence against Persian soldiers amid a rumour that Nadir had been killed, Nadir ordered a massacre.

- [DISCIPLINE] No fixed casualty number is used here because contemporary and later estimates vary widely and are shaped by the rhetoric of catastrophe.
- [FACT] Nadir seized the imperial treasury, levied contributions and took celebrated objects including the Peacock Throne and Koh-i-Noor.
- [FACT] Muhammad Shah retained the throne, while territories west of the Indus and frontier possessions including Thatta passed to Nadir's control.
- [FACT] Nadir withdrew; he did not establish Persian government over Delhi or the Gangetic plain.

Consequence matrix

Dimension	Consequence	Qualification
Prestige	emperor and capital visibly subordinated	Mughal legitimacy still remained useful afterwards
Frontier	loss west of Indus opened the route to later Afghan pressure	Durrani invasions began after Nadir's death, outside the main window
Finance	treasury and elite wealth were removed; fiscal confidence weakened	exact booty totals are contested; regional economy did not uniformly collapse
Court	Khan-i-Dauran and Saadat Khan died; old alignments were disrupted	new factions formed instead of institutional recovery
Regions	zamindars and provincial rulers saw central weakness	regional autonomy was already advanced before 1739
Companies	foreign merchants observed the loss of imperial coercive capacity	Company conquest required later wars, alliances and Bengal revenue

Bounded post-1740 consequence

Nadir's assassination in 1747 enabled Ahmad Shah Durrani to build Afghan power. His first invasion in 1748 was checked near Sirhind, showing that Mughal resistance had not vanished; repeated later invasions nevertheless exploited the frontier opened in 1739. Those later events are consequences, not causes within this package's core period.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - NADIR SHAH'S INVASION, KARNAL AND DELHI, 1738-1739

START / CONCEPT: Nadir Shah's invasion, Karnal and Delhi, 1738-1739

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Nadir Shah's invasion • Karnal • Delhi • Prestige • 1738-1739 • 24 February 1739

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Nadir had rebuilt Persian power through prolonged war and required resources to sustain a large military establishment.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: His first invasion in 1748 was checked near Sirhind, showing that Mughal resistance had not vanished; repeated later invasions nevertheless exploited the frontier opened in 1739.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Nadir's unified command, mobile firepower and tactical control defeated a larger but fragmented imperial host.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Stories that Nizam-ul-Mulk or Saadat Khan invited Nadir lack documentary proof in Satish Chandra's assessment and should not be stated as fact.

SESSION 19 - WHY CENTRAL AUTHORITY DECLINED: MULTI-CAUSAL INTERACTION MODEL

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Why central authority declined: multi-causal interaction model comprises Why central authority declined, multi-causal interaction model and Structural fiscal-military core as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Fiscal stress weakened service; weak service reduced collection; lower collection intensified jagir competition; factional conflict encouraged provincial autonomy; autonomy deprived the centre of resources; and the diminished centre could neither control regional powers nor defend the frontier.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

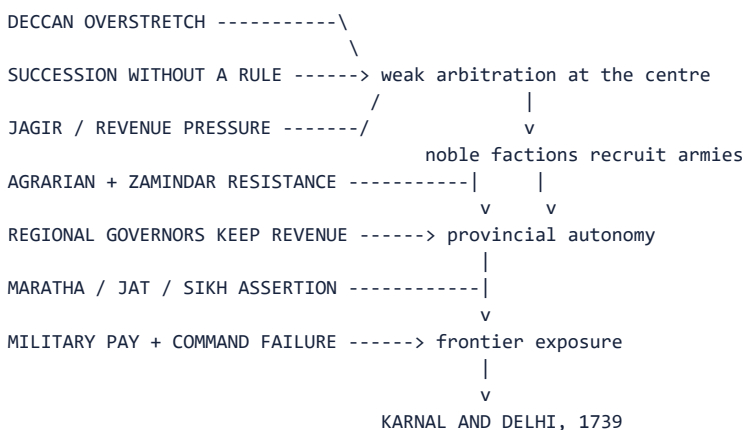
Structural fiscal-military core: the mansab-jagir contract became less credible because dependable assignments, actual collection and service obligations diverged.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Why central authority declined
- multi-causal interaction model
- Structural fiscal-military core
- Political transmission mechanism
- Rural and regional feedback
- Deccan and Maratha pressure

How to use them: Frame the answer through Why central authority declined; define multi-causal interaction model, connect Structural fiscal-military core with Political transmission mechanism to explain the mechanism, and use Rural and regional feedback for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Interaction diagram



Weighted causal hierarchy

1. **Structural fiscal-military core:** the mansab-jagir contract became less credible because dependable assignments, actual collection and service obligations diverged.
2. **Political transmission mechanism:** succession wars and factional control of office prevented the emperor from arbitrating elite competition.
3. **Rural and regional feedback:** extraction and weak supervision strengthened zamindars, peasants, regional governors and armed entrepreneurs.
4. **Deccan and Maratha pressure:** prolonged war consumed resources and then converted Maratha forces into autonomous collectors and imperial brokers.
5. **Military-organisational failure:** contingent shortfalls, arrears, slow logistics and divided command reduced the usable strength of the army.

6. **External shock:** Nadir Shah exploited and publicised the weakness, further reducing prestige and frontier security.

Why single-cause explanations fail

Single cause	What it correctly notices	What it misses
weak successors	succession and royal judgement mattered	capable nobles and deep institutional pressures
Aurangzeb's religion	coalition and legitimacy could be damaged	post-1707 reversal, cross-religious alliances and fiscal mechanisms
noble corruption	appointments, bribery and self-interest weakened service	why incentives changed and resources became contested
peasant revolts	revenue pressure reduced collection	elite leadership, regional growth and political opportunity
Maratha attacks	mobile fiscal-military competition drained provinces	Mughal-Maratha bargaining and internal imperial crisis
Nadir Shah	invasion devastated prestige and frontier security	decline and regional autonomy already preceded 1739
European superiority	later companies possessed maritime-financial advantages	Company territorial rule was not the cause of the 1707-1739 crisis

Synthesis

The decline was a **self-reinforcing loop**. Fiscal stress weakened service; weak service reduced collection; lower collection intensified jagir competition; factional conflict encouraged provincial autonomy; autonomy deprived the centre of resources; and the diminished centre could neither control regional powers nor defend the frontier.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - WHY CENTRAL AUTHORITY DECLINED: MULTI-CAUSAL INTERACTION MODEL

START / CONCEPT: Why central authority declined: multi-causal interaction model

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Why central authority declined • multi-causal interaction model • Structural fiscal-military core • Political transmission mechanism • Rural and regional feedback • Deccan and Maratha pressure

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Fiscal stress weakened service; weak service reduced collection; lower collection intensified jagir competition; factional conflict encouraged provincial autonomy; autonomy deprived the centre of resources; and the diminished centre could neither control regional powers nor defend the frontier.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The decline was a self-reinforcing loop.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the mansab-jagir contract became less credible because dependable assignments, actual collection and service obligations...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Structural fiscal-military core: the mansab-jagir contract became less credible because dependable assignments, actual collection and service obligations diverged.

SESSION 20 - CONTINUITIES AFTER POLITICAL CONTRACTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Continuities after political contraction comprises FORM SURVIVED, FORCE SHIFTED, Timurid emperor and legitimacy reduced the cost of claiming rule as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: They retained imperial forms because those forms remained intelligible to nobles, zamindars, merchants and neighbouring rulers.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

This gap explains why the dynasty survived as a political symbol long after Delhi ceased to command the empire.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Continuities after political contraction
- FORM SURVIVED, FORCE SHIFTED
- Timurid emperor
- legitimacy reduced the cost of claiming rule
- Coin and khutba
- sovereignty remained layered rather than abruptly national

How to use them: Frame the answer through Continuities after political contraction; define FORM SURVIVED, FORCE SHIFTED, connect Timurid emperor with legitimacy reduced the cost of claiming rule to explain the mechanism, and use Coin and khutba for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Continuity map

Surviving Mughal element	Evidence in the transition	Why it mattered
Timurid emperor	rival nobles and provinces still sought titles and confirmation	legitimacy reduced the cost of claiming rule
Coin and khutba	successor states retained the emperor's name	sovereignty remained layered rather than abruptly national
Mansab and office vocabulary	Nizam, Awadh and Bengal used imperial ranks and posts	administrative personnel and expectations remained portable
Revenue institutions	jagir, khalisa, zamindar, diwan and Persian records continued	regional states inherited a working fiscal language
Farman and sanad	Company and Maratha rights were framed through imperial grants	legal memory shaped later disputes
Persianate culture	chronicles, painting, music, etiquette and chancery practice continued	regional courts localised rather than discarded Mughal forms
Delhi as symbol	control of emperor and capital remained politically valuable	later Marathas and Company used Mughal sanction

Core teaching

- [FACT] Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad did not initially declare modern sovereignty. They retained imperial forms because those forms remained intelligible to nobles, zamindars, merchants and neighbouring rulers.
- [FACT] Regional rulers sought confirmation, titles and succession approval through gifts and court diplomacy even while withholding effective obedience.
- [FACT] Maratha leaders sought formal sanads for fiscal rights. Imperial recognition could convert repeated exaction into a claim of lawful collection.
- [FACT] The Company relied on Farrukhsiyar's farman and later Mughal grants in its legal-political arguments. A weakening emperor could still issue documents with consequences.
- [ANALYSIS] Symbolic sovereignty was not the opposite of real power. It was a resource that regional powers used to stabilise new authority.
- [CULTURE] Administrative Persian, courtly forms, music, painting and architecture moved into regional capitals. The political centre fragmented more quickly than the cultural-administrative ecumene.
- [VERDICT] Mughal power declined before Mughal legitimacy. This gap explains why the dynasty survived as a political symbol long after Delhi ceased to command the empire.

Memory hook

FORM SURVIVED, FORCE SHIFTED: titles, coins, khutba, revenue language and Persianate culture remained; enforceable command and remittance moved to regions.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CONTINUITIES AFTER POLITICAL CONTRACTION

START / CONCEPT: Continuities after political contraction

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Continuities after political contraction • FORM SURVIVED, FORCE SHIFTED • Timurid emperor • legitimacy reduced the cost of claiming rule • Coin and khutba • sovereignty remained layered rather than abruptly national

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: They retained imperial forms because those forms remained intelligible to nobles, zamindars, merchants and neighbouring rulers.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Symbolic sovereignty was not the opposite of real power.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: imperial recognition could convert repeated exaction into a claim of lawful collection.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: This gap explains why the dynasty survived as a political symbol long after Delhi ceased to command the empire.

SESSION 21 - HISTORIOGRAPHY: DARK AGE, CRISIS OR REGIONAL TRANSITION?

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Historiography improves the answer when each interpretation is tied to its evidence.

Technical definition: Delhi suffered catastrophic violence in 1739, and warfare burdened cultivators and trade routes. [ARGUMENT AGAINST UNIVERSAL DECLINE] Bengal and other regions retained commercial vitality; local agrarian expansion and banking networks financed successor states; Delhi's cultural and economic life recovered; Mughal institutions remained productive outside the centre. [BEST VERDICT] "Dark age" is too total, while "regional vitality" is too celebratory.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Delhi suffered catastrophic violence in 1739, and warfare burdened cultivators and trade routes. [ARGUMENT AGAINST UNIVERSAL DECLINE] Bengal and other regions retained commercial vitality; local agrarian expansion and banking networks financed successor states; Delhi's cultural and economic life recovered; Mughal institutions remained productive outside the centre. [BEST VERDICT] "Dark age" is too total, while "regional vitality" is too celebratory.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Historiography
- dark age
- Jadunath Sarkar and older imperial narratives
- Aurangzeb, weak successors, moral and military decline
- ruler-centred chronology and political narrative
- risks communal, moralising and teleological explanation

How to use them: Frame the answer through Historiography; define dark age, connect Jadunath Sarkar and older imperial narratives with Aurangzeb, weak successors, moral and military decline to explain the mechanism, and use ruler-centred chronology and political narrative for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Historiographical debate

Historian or school	Main emphasis	Evidence contribution	Limitation or reply
Jadunath Sarkar and older imperial narratives	Aurangzeb, weak successors, moral and military decline	ruler-centred chronology and political narrative	risks communal, moralising and teleological explanation
Satish Chandra	jagirdari crisis, Deccan strain, factions and administrative-social mechanism	links elite assignment to rural and military effects	should not be universalised without regional variation
Irfan Habib / Aligarh materialist approach	agrarian crisis and surplus extraction	places peasants, zamindars and revenue relations beneath court politics	resistance did not always mean falling production
M. Athar Ali	composition and politics of Mughal nobility; critique of over-decentralised readings	explains elite structure and continuing imperial cohesion	court evidence can overshadow local networks
John F. Richards	allocation choices and Deccan khalisa complicate a simple shortage thesis	asks whether crisis was policy-made as well as resource-made	actual realisation, insecurity and service obligations still constrained the system
Muzaffar Alam	regional politics and continuing Mughal idiom in Awadh and Punjab	shows decentralisation without instant institutional rupture	regional formation involved conflict and unequal social costs
C.A. Bayly	commercial, credit and "portfolio" resources of local groups	reveals bankers, merchants and local elites as political actors	commercial vitality cannot erase imperial military decline
Revisionist synthesis	eighteenth century as transition and regionalisation	explains Bengal, Awadh, Hyderabad and urban-cultural vitality	can understate war, peasant pressure and the centre's real collapse

Dark-age debate

- [ARGUMENT FOR DECLINE] The imperial treasury, army discipline, frontier and provincial remittance deteriorated. Delhi suffered catastrophic violence in 1739, and warfare burdened cultivators and trade routes.
- [ARGUMENT AGAINST UNIVERSAL DECLINE] Bengal and other regions retained commercial vitality; local agrarian expansion and banking networks financed successor states; Delhi's cultural and economic life recovered; Mughal institutions remained productive outside the centre.
- [BEST VERDICT] "Dark age" is too total, while "regional vitality" is too celebratory. The period combined central fiscal-military collapse, regional state formation, continuing commerce and culture, and uneven social suffering.

Historiographical answer flow

define the level of decline

- > older ruler-centred explanation
- > structural jagirdari and agrarian explanation
- > revisionist regional evidence
- > source and regional limits
- > two-level verdict: centre declined, regions reorganised unevenly

Source-critical verdict

Historiography improves the answer when each interpretation is tied to its evidence. Do not merely list historians. Use Sarkar for the older political thesis, Chandra and Habib for mechanisms, Richards for qualification, and Alam/Bayly for regional redistribution.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - HISTORIOGRAPHY: DARK AGE, CRISIS OR REGIONAL TRANSITION?

START / CONCEPT: Historiography: dark age, crisis or regional transition?

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v

EXACT TERMS: Historiography · dark age · Jadunath Sarkar and older imperial narratives · Aurangzeb, weak successors, moral and military decline · ruler-centred chronology and political narrative · risks communal, moralising and teleological explanation

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Historiography improves the answer when each interpretation is tied to its evidence.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Use Sarkar for the older political thesis, Chandra and Habib for mechanisms, Richards for qualification, and Alam/Bayly for regional redistribution.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: delhi suffered catastrophic violence in 1739.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Delhi suffered catastrophic violence in 1739, and warfare burdened cultivators and trade routes. [ARGUMENT AGAINST UNIVERSAL DECLINE] Bengal and other regions retained commercial vitality; local agrarian expansion and banking networks financed successor states; Delhi's cultural and economic life recovered; Mughal institutions remained productive outside the centre. [BEST VERDICT] "Dark age" is too total, while "regional vitality" is too celebratory.

SESSION 22 - TERMINOLOGY, TIMELINE, MEMORY HOOKS AND ANSWER TOOLKIT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Terminology, timeline, memory hooks and answer toolkit comprises Terminology, timeline and memory hooks as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Technically, Terminology, timeline, memory hooks and answer toolkit is analysed by relating Terminology to timeline, then testing the relationship through memory hooks and toolkit.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Terminology, timeline, memory hooks and answer toolkit comprises Terminology, timeline and memory hooks as its core connected dimensions.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Terminology
- timeline
- memory hooks
- toolkit
- Mansab
- Jagir

How to use them: Frame the answer through Terminology; define timeline, connect memory hooks with toolkit to explain the mechanism, and use Mansab for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Timeline ladder

Date	Event	One-line significance
1680s-1707	final Deccan phase under Aurangzeb	military-fiscal over-extension and unresolved Maratha resistance
1707	Aurangzeb dies; Jajau	succession reopens elite competition
1709	Kam Bakhsh defeated	succession among Aurangzeb's sons ends
1712	Bahadur Shah dies	rapid court instability follows
1713	Farrukhsiyar installed	Sayyid kingmaker power becomes decisive
1717	Bengal governorship of Murshid Quli; Company farman	regional autonomy and commercial privilege deepen
1718-19	Sayyid-Maratha settlement and sanads	Maratha fiscal claims enter imperial bargaining
1719	Farrukhsiyar deposed; rapid emperors; Muhammad Shah installed	monarchy visibly dependent on noble coalitions
1720	Sayyid power overthrown	Turani-led counter-coalition restores but cannot repair the centre
1722	Nizam becomes wazir; Saadat Khan appointed Awadh	reform at Delhi and state formation in the province
1724	Nizam consolidates Hyderabad	office becomes hereditary regional power
1730s	Maratha expansion in Malwa and Gujarat	Deccan challenge becomes north Indian fiscal pressure
1739	Karnal and Delhi	external shock exposes the hollowed fiscal-military core
1740	Alivardi Khan takes Bengal	bounded marker of stronger regional autonomy
1747-48	Nadir dies; first Durrani invasion; Muhammad Shah dies	post-1740 frontier consequence, not core cause

Terminology bank

- **Mansab:** numerical rank defining status and service obligation.
- **Jagir:** transferable revenue assignment used to meet salary and service.
- **Khalisa:** land revenue more directly reserved for the crown.
- **Be-jagiri:** absence or delay of a suitable jagir for a claimant.
- **Jama / hasil:** assessed demand / revenue actually realised.
- **Ijara:** revenue farming to a contractor.
- **Subah / sarkar / pargana:** descending territorial-administrative units.
- **Wazir:** chief minister and central coordinator, especially of finance and administration.
- **Mir bakhshi:** high military-pay and mansab office.
- **Chauth / sardeshmukhi:** Maratha fiscal claims conventionally represented as one-fourth and an additional ten per cent.
- **Khutba:** Friday sermon in a ruler's name, a marker of acknowledged sovereignty.
- **Farman / sanad:** imperial order / documentary grant or confirmation.
- **Successor state:** a Mughal province converted into hereditary practical autonomy while retaining imperial forms.

Memory hooks

- **S-J-A-M-N:** Succession -> Jagir pressure -> Agrarian resistance -> Military weakness -> Nadir.
- **B-A-H:** Bengal, Awadh, Hyderabad = provincial office + regional resources + nominal homage.
- **FORM/FORCE:** Mughal form survived; coercive force shifted.
- **1739 is an X-ray, not the disease:** Karnal exposed structures already weakened.
- **Centre versus region:** political contraction at Delhi can coexist with commercial and cultural vitality elsewhere.

High-frequency traps

- The empire did not end in 1707.
- Sayyid Brothers were kingmakers, not emperors.
- Nizam-ul-Mulk did not proclaim a modern independent nation-state in 1724.
- Chauth was not a religious tax.
- Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad were not identical.
- Nadir Shah did not annex and govern the Gangetic plain.
- Do not quote a Delhi massacre casualty total as settled fact.
- Do not call the eighteenth century uniformly stagnant.
- Do not treat Mughal artillery as absent; coordination and logistics were the issue.
- Do not project later British paramountcy backward as inevitable.

Mark-scaled answer architecture

Marks	Structure	Evidence density
10	direct thesis + three causal/evidentiary blocks + one qualification + verdict	2-3 named units
15	thesis + structural mechanism + political/rural interaction + counter-evidence + verdict	4-6 named units
20	define level + weighted causal hierarchy + regional variation + historiography/source criticism + graded verdict	5-8 named units

Universal answer spine

DIRECT THESIS

- > define decline at the correct level
- > claim + named evidence + significance + limit
- > repeat across structural, political, regional and external dimensions
- > include counter-evidence on continuity/vitality
- > conclude with a weighted, two-level verdict

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - TERMINOLOGY, TIMELINE, MEMORY HOOKS AND ANSWER TOOLKIT

START / CONCEPT: Terminology, timeline, memory hooks and answer toolkit

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Terminology • timeline • memory hooks • toolkit • Mansab • Jagir

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Centre versus region: political contraction at Delhi can coexist with commercial and cultural vitality elsewhere.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Do not treat Mughal artillery as absent; coordination and logistics were the issue.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Sayyid Brothers were kingmakers, not emperors.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Terminology, timeline, memory hooks and answer toolkit comprises Terminology, timeline and memory hooks as its core connected dimensions.

MODERN HISTORY DEEP-REVIEW CORE CONTROL

- **Must remember:** Aurangzeb's death in 1707 begins the core sequence; succession wars, factional competition, jagirdari-fiscal stress, regional assertion and Nadir Shah's 1739 invasion interacted.
- **Close distinction:** Decline of enforceable central command did not mean instant state collapse, civilisational decline or disappearance of Mughal titles, revenue forms and Persianate legitimacy.
- **Evidence / interpretation limit:** Satish Chandra's jagirdari analysis, regional-state evidence and court chronicles must be compared; no single-ruler or British-inevitability thesis is sufficient.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which formulation best defines Mughal decline in this package?

Which formulation best defines Mughal decline in this package?

A. Loss of enforceable central fiscal-military authority amid continuing institutions and legitimacy B. Replacement of Persian administration by Company rule in 1719 C. Immediate disappearance of the dynasty in 1707 D. Uniform collapse of every regional economy

Answer: A.

Explanation: Decline is level-specific: central command contracted while the dynasty, revenue idiom and cultural order persisted.

Trap logic: Do not equate imperial contraction with instant civilisational collapse.

Q2. Which sequence correctly describes the administrative scale from smaller to larger?

Which sequence correctly describes the administrative scale from smaller to larger?

A. Pargana -> subah -> sarkar B. Pargana -> sarkar -> subah C. Subah -> pargana -> sarkar D. Sarkar -> subah -> pargana

Answer: B.

Explanation: A pargana grouped villages, a sarkar grouped parganas and a subah was the larger province.

Trap logic: UPSC often reverses the middle and upper units.

Q3. Canonical concept check 3

Be-jagiri most precisely referred to:

A. Permanent hereditary ownership of crown land B. A Maratha levy on Mughal provinces C. Lack or delay of a suitable jagir for a claimant D. Confiscation of all zamindari rights

Answer: C.

Explanation: Be-jagiri identifies assignment scarcity or delay within the mansab-jagir system.

Trap logic: It is not a general word for corruption.

Q4. Which is the strongest qualification to a single-cause 'weak successors' thesis?

Which is the strongest qualification to a single-cause 'weak successors' thesis?

A. Succession ceased to matter after Bahadur Shah B. Provincial governors possessed no independent revenue base C. Every post-1707 emperor was militarily stronger than Aurangzeb D. Capable nobles existed, but incentives directed their capacity into factional and regional power

Answer: D.

Explanation: Zulfiqar Khan, the Sayyids, Nizam-ul-Mulk and Murshid Quli Khan show that talent survived while institutional alignment failed.

Trap logic: Do not replace a ruler-only thesis with a nobles-only thesis.

Q5. Canonical concept check 5

Bahadur Shah I's Deccan policy is best described as:

- A. Partial conciliation that recognised sardeshmukhi but failed to settle chauth and Maratha succession B. Total military destruction of Maratha power C. Transfer of Hyderabad to the English Company D. Full recognition of Tarabai as sole Maratha ruler

Answer: A.

Explanation: His policy tried accommodation but left Shahu-Tarabai rivalry and fiscal claims unresolved.

Trap logic: Partial concessions are not the same as a durable settlement.

Q6. Canonical concept check 6

Zulfiqar Khan's importance lies primarily in:

- A. Defeating Nadir Shah at Karnal B. Showing both the administrative potential and coalition danger of a powerful wazir C. Founding the state of Bengal D. Abolishing the mansabdari system

Answer: B.

Explanation: He pursued conciliation and fiscal restraint, but emperor and nobles feared an over-mighty minister.

Trap logic: Avoid reducing his career to Jahandar Shah's court anecdotes.

Q7. Canonical concept check 7

The Sayyid Brothers' conflict with Farrukhsiyar centred most directly on:

- A. A doctrinal dispute over Sufi orders alone B. Company annexation of Bengal C. Control of appointments, seal, jagirs, army and provincial resources D. Whether Persian should replace Turkish

Answer: C.

Explanation: The struggle concerned the operational levers of sovereignty.

Trap logic: Religious slogans used later by opponents do not define the original institutional dispute.

Q8. Which statement about the Sayyid Brothers is incorrect?

Which statement about the Sayyid Brothers is incorrect?

- A. They helped place Farrukhsiyar on the throne B. Their deposition of Farrukhsiyar damaged monarchical prestige C. They pursued conciliation with Rajputs, Jats and Marathas D. They formally abolished the Mughal dynasty and founded their own royal house

Answer: D.

Explanation: They remained kingmakers within the Timurid framework and never founded a Sayyid imperial dynasty.

Trap logic: Kingmaker does not mean emperor.

Q9. Canonical concept check 9

The 1718-19 Maratha settlement associated with the Sayyids sought to:

- A. Exchange recognition of Shahu's claims and fiscal rights for service and political support B. Transfer Bengal customs to the Marathas C. Make Nizam-ul-Mulk Peshwa D. End all Maratha collection outside the swarajya

Answer: A.

Explanation: The settlement tried to convert conflict into regulated fiscal-military partnership.

Trap logic: Legal recognition did not guarantee uniform implementation.

Q10. Why was Muhammad Shah's early reign still a possible recovery moment?

Why was Muhammad Shah's early reign still a possible recovery moment?

- A. The jagirdari system had already been abolished B. Chronological stability, continuing prestige and surviving military-administrative resources remained C. Nadir Shah had become a Mughal ally D. All provinces resumed full remittance

Answer: B.

Explanation: The early 1720s retained resources that a coherent centre might have mobilised.

Trap logic: Recovery was possible, not assured.

Q11. Canonical concept check 11

Nizam-ul-Mulk's move to the Deccan in 1724 is best understood as:

- A. A nationalist declaration against all Mughal culture B. A complete rejection of coins and khutba in the emperor's name C. Conversion of imperial office and military networks into practical regional autonomy D. An English-sponsored conquest of Hyderabad

Answer: C.

Explanation: Hyderabad retained imperial forms while command and revenue became regional.

Trap logic: Autonomy is not identical to formal modern independence.

Q12. Which pairing is correctly matched?

Which pairing is correctly matched?

- A. Churaman - foundation of the Nizamat of Arcot B. Nizam-ul-Mulk - foundation of Bengal C. Murshid Quli Khan - foundation of Hyderabad D. Saadat Khan - foundation of autonomous Awadh

Answer: D.

Explanation: Saadat Khan was appointed to Awadh in 1722 and built its semi-autonomous order.

Trap logic: Successor-state founders are a frequent attribution trap.

Q13. Canonical concept check 13

Turani, Irani, Afghan and Hindustani labels should be treated as:

- A. Recruitment and affinity networks within fluid coalitions B. Fixed modern political parties with permanent manifestos C. Revenue units below the pargana D. Religious sects with no connection to office

Answer: A.

Explanation: Origin and kinship mattered, but alliances shifted around office, jagirs and survival.

Trap logic: Do not harden flexible court blocs into permanent ethnic parties.

Q14. Which mechanism most directly links jagir pressure to military weakness?

Which mechanism most directly links jagir pressure to military weakness?

- A. Jagirdars were legally forbidden to employ cavalry B. Inadequate yields and arrears encouraged mansabdars to maintain fewer troops than sanctioned C. Khalisa revenue automatically went to Maratha forts D. All artillery was owned by zamindars

Answer: B.

Explanation: The service bargain failed when paper rank and real fiscal support diverged.

Trap logic: A large mansab did not guarantee a field-ready contingent.

Q15. Canonical concept check 15

The jama-hasil gap refers to the difference between:

- A. Chauth and sardeshmukhi
- B. Imperial coin and provincial coin
- C. Assessed revenue and revenue actually realised
- D. Cavalry rank and infantry rank

Answer: C.

Explanation: Paper assessment could exceed collection because of resistance, devastation or administrative weakness.

Trap logic: Do not confuse assessment with cash available to the army.

Q16. Canonical concept check 16

John F. Richards's qualification to a simple jagir-shortage thesis stresses that:

- A. No jagirdari problem existed anywhere
- B. Only religious policy mattered
- C. Bengal had ceased cultivation by 1700
- D. Allocation choices and the treatment of Deccan khalisa could make the crisis partly policy-produced

Answer: D.

Explanation: Resources, allocation and realisation must be distinguished.

Trap logic: A qualification is not a total rejection of fiscal crisis.

Q17. Ijara created which recurring risk?

Ijara created which recurring risk?

- A. A contractor's incentive to extract above the fixed payment promised to government
- B. A ban on cash revenue
- C. Permanent restoration of village autonomy
- D. Automatic conversion of peasants into mansabdars

Answer: A.

Explanation: Revenue farming inserted cash-rich intermediaries whose profit could intensify pressure.

Trap logic: It could coexist with commercial sophistication and coercion.

Q18. Which statement best captures zamindars in the Mughal order?

Which statement best captures zamindars in the Mughal order?

- A. They were identical to European freehold landlords
- B. They were local right-holders and armed intermediaries whose cooperation or resistance shaped collection
- C. They had no role in peasant mobilisation
- D. They were salaried clerks without local ties

Answer: B.

Explanation: Zamindars linked the state to locality and could convert that position into rebellion or rule.

Trap logic: Avoid both 'mere collector' and 'absolute owner'.

Q19. Canonical concept check 19

The most balanced reading of peasant participation in Jat or Sikh assertion is:

- A. Religion alone explains every participant
- B. Peasants acted without any intermediaries
- C. Agrarian grievance became durable through local leadership, identity, forts and armed organisation
- D. Revenue pressure played no role

Answer: C.

Explanation: Material grievance and political organisation worked together.

Trap logic: Do not erase either agrarian structure or identity.

Q20. Which claim about eighteenth-century agriculture is safest?

Which claim about eighteenth-century agriculture is safest?

A. Only European capital financed agriculture B. Cultivation stopped throughout India after 1707 C. Every region experienced equal prosperity D. Severe extraction and resistance coexisted with expansion and monetisation in some regions

Answer: D.

Explanation: Regional variation is essential to the decline-versus-transition debate.

Trap logic: Do not convert a regional example into an all-India total.

Q21. Canonical concept check 21

Chauth is best described as:

A. A Maratha claim conventionally represented as one-fourth of assessed revenue B. A ten per cent imperial customs duty C. A Mughal tax on non-Muslims D. The salary rank of a mansabdar

Answer: A.

Explanation: Chauth was a fiscal-political claim imposed or negotiated in territories beyond the core swarajya.

Trap logic: It was not simply a village land-revenue rate.

Q22. Canonical concept check 22

Sardeshmukhi is conventionally distinguished from chauth as:

A. A Sikh levy in Punjab B. An additional ten per cent claim linked to superior regional right C. A synonym for imperial khalisa D. A European sea customs pass

Answer: B.

Explanation: The two Maratha claims had distinct conventional bases even when bargained together.

Trap logic: Do not reverse the quarter and ten-per-cent associations.

Q23. Why did the 1718-19 Maratha settlement not end Deccan conflict?

Why did the 1718-19 Maratha settlement not end Deccan conflict?

A. The Deccan had no local forts or sardars B. The settlement contained no fiscal provisions C. Competing Maratha, Mughal and Nizam interests made legal recognition difficult to enforce D. Shahu immediately abolished the Peshwa's office

Answer: C.

Explanation: A sanad could frame rights but not eliminate rival collectors and political centres.

Trap logic: Documentary grant is not uniform implementation.

Q24. Canonical concept check 24

Baji Rao I's wider significance within this topic is:

A. He founded Awadh in 1722 B. He restored Mughal control over Punjab C. He led Nadir Shah's Persian army D. He shifted Maratha strategy toward sustained expansion into Malwa, Gujarat and north Indian politics

Answer: D.

Explanation: Maratha pressure moved from Deccan survival to wider fiscal and political reach.

Trap logic: Reach should not be equated with uniform territorial administration.

Q25. Canonical concept check 25

Churaman is associated with:

- A. Jat power in the Agra-Mathura region B. Persian victory at Karnal C. Sikh mobilisation at Lohgarh D. Hyderabad's foundation

Answer: A.

Explanation: Churaman's networks illustrate fortified zamindari and negotiated resistance.

Trap logic: Do not confuse Jat and Sikh leaders.

Q26. Canonical concept check 26

Banda Bahadur's movement is important because it:

- A. Served as Nadir Shah's frontier army B. Combined Sikh political-religious mobilisation with a major challenge to Mughal authority in Punjab C. Created the twelve misls after 1765 within this period D. Established Bengal's revenue administration

Answer: B.

Explanation: The movement survived the limits of Bahadur Shah's campaigning even though later Sikh phases lay beyond the core period.

Trap logic: Do not begin Sikh political history with Ranjit Singh.

Q27. Which statement about Rajput politics is most accurate?

Which statement about Rajput politics is most accurate?

- A. Their conflicts were purely religious B. Rajputs ceased receiving mansabs after 1707 C. Rajput rulers could seek high Mughal office while bargaining for regional autonomy D. All Rajput houses formed one permanent anti-Mughal coalition

Answer: C.

Explanation: Jai Singh and Ajit Singh demonstrate simultaneous imperial participation and regional assertion.

Trap logic: Avoid binary loyalist/rebel labels.

Q28. Canonical concept check 28

The strongest common feature of Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad was:

- A. Direct creation by Ahmad Shah Durrani B. Formal republican constitutions C. Complete abolition of Persian administration D. Provincial office converted into hereditary autonomy while Mughal legitimacy was retained

Answer: D.

Explanation: All three were successor states, but each rested on a distinct regional base.

Trap logic: Common origin does not make their later institutions identical.

Q29. Canonical concept check 29

Murshid Quli Khan's Bengal order depended significantly on:

- A. Tight revenue collection, major zamindars and merchant-bankers B. Maratha control of the Bengal mint C. Direct annual election by village councils D. Abolition of land revenue

Answer: A.

Explanation: Provincial fiscal capacity rested on collaboration with landed and financial elites.

Trap logic: Efficient collection could still be socially coercive.

Q30. Canonical concept check 30

The Jagat Seth house illustrates:

A. A Sikh misl in Punjab B. The political importance of credit, remittance and mint-linked finance in Bengal C. The disappearance of Indian bankers before Plassey D. A Mughal artillery corps

Answer: B.

Explanation: Bankers were not decorative merchants; they connected revenue, government and political coalition.

Trap logic: Commercial vitality did not guarantee political neutrality.

Q31. Which best describes Saadat Khan's relation to Delhi?

Which best describes Saadat Khan's relation to Delhi?

A. He immediately rejected every Mughal title B. He became Peshwa after Baji Rao C. He built Awadh autonomy while continuing to seek imperial office and confirmation D. He ruled Bengal as Murshid Quli's deputy

Answer: C.

Explanation: Provincial state-building and court ambition remained intertwined.

Trap logic: Do not project later complete separation backward.

Q32. Canonical concept check 32

Hyderabad's continued use of the emperor's name on coins and in khutba indicates:

A. Absence of any regional autonomy B. Direct daily taxation by Delhi C. Conversion of Hyderabad into a European colony D. Layered sovereignty and the continuing value of Mughal legitimacy

Answer: D.

Explanation: Symbolic recognition coexisted with practical independence in war, appointment and revenue.

Trap logic: Symbols are politically real but not proof of direct control.

Q33. Which statement correctly distinguishes the three successor states?

Which statement correctly distinguishes the three successor states?

A. Bengal was strongly commercial-fiscal, Awadh a Ganga-plain military-revenue state, Hyderabad a contested Deccan polity B. They had identical elite coalitions and geography C. All three were founded after Nadir Shah's death D. Only Awadh retained Mughal forms

Answer: A.

Explanation: Common Mughal ancestry produced different regional trajectories.

Trap logic: A matrix answer earns more than a generic list.

Q34. Why is the phrase 'political vacuum' inadequate?

Why is the phrase 'political vacuum' inadequate?

A. No territory changed political hands B. Regional states, zamindars, Marathas and financiers exercised organised power as Delhi weakened C. European companies withdrew from India D. The emperor maintained full coercive control

Answer: B.

Explanation: Power was redistributed, not removed from society.

Trap logic: Rejecting 'vacuum' does not deny violent instability.

Q35. Which was a central military weakness of the later Mughal host?

Which was a central military weakness of the later Mughal host?

- A. Legal prohibition on cavalry B. Dependence solely on European infantry C. Composite contingents and factional commanders lacked reliable unified coordination D. Complete absence of artillery

Answer: C.

Explanation: Karnal shows how divided leadership nullified considerable resources.

Trap logic: Do not use a crude technology-only explanation.

Q36. Canonical concept check 36

A high mansab in 1739 did not necessarily reveal:

- A. The holder's nominal rank B. A recognised service status C. A claim on imperial patronage D. The number of paid, equipped and deployable soldiers actually present

Answer: D.

Explanation: Fiscal shortfalls and inspection weakness separated paper strength from battlefield strength.

Trap logic: Nominal figures should not be treated as headcounts.

Q37. Canonical concept check 37

Nadir Shah's comparative military advantage is best stated as:

- A. Unified command, mobility, disciplined fire and flexible use of artillery B. Naval blockade of Delhi C. Exclusive possession of all gunpowder technology D. Support from a united Mughal nobility

Answer: A.

Explanation: The Mughals had guns; Nadir integrated force and decision more effectively.

Trap logic: Avoid 'modern guns versus medieval swords'.

Q38. Canonical concept check 38

The northwest frontier failed before Karnal mainly because:

- A. Nadir approached through Bengal B. Warnings, diplomacy, reinforcement and command were not converted into a coherent defensive system C. Kabul had never been connected to Mughal strategy D. The Marathas controlled Qandahar

Answer: B.

Explanation: The court received embassies and reports but lacked timely institutional response.

Trap logic: Information alone is not preparedness.

Q39. Canonical concept check 39

Farrukhsiyar's 1717 farman to the English Company primarily concerned:

- A. Transfer of Bengal sovereignty to the Company B. Military conquest of Hyderabad C. Commercial privileges in Bengal, later contested through passes and private trade D. Appointment of a Company governor of Awadh

Answer: C.

Explanation: The farman was a legal-commercial privilege with later political consequences.

Trap logic: Do not convert trade privilege into territorial grant.

Q40. Which economic statement is most defensible?

Which economic statement is most defensible?

A. Bengal trade ended in 1717 B. Delhi had no commerce after 1739 C. Every rupee not sent to Delhi disappeared from circulation D. Decline in imperial remittance could coexist with stronger regional treasuries and markets

Answer: D.

Explanation: Resources were redistributed toward regions, though social costs and war remained.

Trap logic: Centre and region must be analysed separately.

Q41. Canonical concept check 41

Satish Chandra's caution about Nadir Shah's booty is used to show that:

A. Famous totals should not be treated as proof of immediate all-India economic collapse B. The Peacock Throne remained in the Diwan-i-Khas C. The invasion had no fiscal effect D. No treasure was removed from Delhi

Answer: A.

Explanation: Plunder was severe, but the scale and long-term economic interpretation require qualification.

Trap logic: Avoid both exaggeration and minimisation.

Q42. Canonical concept check 42

Muhammad Shah's patronage of music and painting demonstrates:

A. Cultural patronage automatically restored provincial remittance B. Cultural vitality could coexist with political and military contraction C. Court music caused the jagirdari crisis D. Regional courts stopped supporting artists

Answer: B.

Explanation: Culture is an independent evidentiary dimension, not a proxy for governance.

Trap logic: Do not moralise aesthetic life into causation.

Q43. Canonical concept check 43

Dargah Quli Khan's Muraqqa-i Dehli is especially useful for:

A. Exact all-India peasant income statistics B. Official Persian casualty totals at Karnal C. Urban and courtly life in Muhammad Shah's Delhi D. The legal text of the 1717 farman

Answer: C.

Explanation: It supplies an urban social view that complements political chronicles.

Trap logic: Delhi-centred observation cannot represent every region.

Q44. Which was a plausible motive for Nadir Shah's invasion?

Which was a plausible motive for Nadir Shah's invasion?

A. A plan to establish permanent Persian rule over Bengal B. A Sikh request to conquer Delhi C. A verified invitation from Nizam and Saadat Khan D. Resources for a war-making Persian state combined with Mughal frontier weakness

Answer: D.

Explanation: Fiscal-military motive, wealth and opportunity explain more than unsupported invitation stories.

Trap logic: Satish Chandra notes no documentary proof of the invitation claim.

Q45. Canonical concept check 45

The conventional modern date of the Battle of Karnal is:

A. 24 February 1739 B. 24 February 1748 C. 13 March 1757 D. 13 January 1719

Answer: A.

Explanation: Modern reference works conventionally date Karnal to 24 February 1739.

Trap logic: Do not confuse Karnal with the first Durrani invasion in 1748.

Q46. Canonical concept check 46

Karnal is best interpreted as:

A. The origin of every Mughal problem B. An external battlefield test that exposed pre-existing fiscal and command weakness C. A Maratha victory over Nadir Shah D. The formal end of the Mughal dynasty

Answer: B.

Explanation: The invasion accelerated and publicised decline already visible in factions and regions.

Trap logic: Event and structural cause must be separated.

Q47. Which claim about the Delhi massacre is methodologically safest?

Which claim about the Delhi massacre is methodologically safest?

A. The event was invented by Company records B. Every chronicle gives the same number C. The massacre occurred, but a single precise casualty total should not be asserted as settled D. No civilian violence occurred

Answer: C.

Explanation: Catastrophe is certain; totals vary across rhetorical and retrospective sources.

Trap logic: Numerical restraint is evidence discipline, not denial.

Q48. Nadir Shah's settlement with Muhammad Shah did which of the following?

Nadir Shah's settlement with Muhammad Shah did which of the following?

A. Installed the Sayyid Brothers as rulers B. Abolished the Mughal dynasty C. Annexed the whole Gangetic plain to Persia D. Left Muhammad Shah on the throne while transferring wealth and frontier territories west of the Indus

Answer: D.

Explanation: Nadir extracted and withdrew rather than constructing Persian government over north India.

Trap logic: Plunder and annexation west of the Indus are distinct from ruling Delhi.

Q49. Which was not a consequence of 1739?

Which was not a consequence of 1739?

A. Immediate uniform destruction of all Indian trade and urban life B. Greater frontier exposure C. Encouragement to provincial and local assertion D. Severe loss of imperial prestige

Answer: A.

Explanation: Delhi and regional commerce showed resilience even after a severe political-fiscal shock.

Trap logic: Do not infer all-India collapse from capital-city catastrophe.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q50. Canonical concept check 50

The first Durrani invasion in 1748 is used here only to show:

A. The root cause of the 1707 succession war B. A bounded frontier consequence after Nadir's death and the continued possibility of Mughal resistance C. The end of Maratha power in the Deccan D. The creation of Rohilkhand

Answer: B.

Explanation: It lies at the edge of scope and should not displace the 1707-1739 explanation.

Trap logic: Keep later Afghan history bounded.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q51. Which causal ordering is strongest?

Which causal ordering is strongest?

A. Culture declined, therefore jagirs disappeared B. Company trade ended, therefore Bengal became rich C. Fiscal strain weakened service; weak service reduced collection; lower collection intensified faction and autonomy D. Nadir invaded, therefore Aurangzeb fought in the Deccan

Answer: C.

Explanation: The decline operated through a self-reinforcing fiscal-political loop.

Trap logic: Good answers explain mechanisms, not just list factors.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q52. Which statement best captures Mughal continuity?

Which statement best captures Mughal continuity?

A. Every successor state abolished mansabs immediately B. The khutba lost all political meaning C. Persian ceased to be used after 1707 D. Regional powers appropriated imperial titles, documents and revenue practices even as Delhi lost command

Answer: D.

Explanation: Continuity lowered the legitimacy cost of regional state formation.

Trap logic: Institutional survival does not mean unchanged operation.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q53. Canonical concept check 53

Muzaffar Alam and C.A. Bayly are most useful for arguing that:

A. The eighteenth century involved regional reordering, commercial networks and redistributed power B. The Mughal centre remained fully sovereign C. Nadir Shah created Bengal's banking system D. Agrarian pressure never existed

Answer: A.

Explanation: Revisionist work corrects a total-dark-age narrative.

Trap logic: It must be balanced against warfare and unequal social costs.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q54. Canonical concept check 54

Jadunath Sarkar's older interpretation is most often associated with:

- A. The claim that jagirs never existed B. Aurangzeb-centred, personality, moral and political decline C. A denial that emperors mattered D. The portfolio-capital thesis

Answer: B.

Explanation: The older view supplies political narrative but risks moral and communal reduction.

Trap logic: Name the interpretation and then qualify it.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q55. Which is the best historiographical synthesis?

Which is the best historiographical synthesis?

- A. Every region followed the same agrarian trajectory B. No meaningful decline occurred at any level C. Central fiscal-military decline plus uneven regional state formation and continuing economic-cultural vitality D. Only moral decay mattered

Answer: C.

Explanation: A two-level, regionally qualified verdict incorporates the strongest evidence.

Trap logic: Balance does not mean treating every thesis as equally explanatory.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q56. Canonical concept check 56

A coin in Muhammad Shah's name issued within a successor state most directly proves:

- A. Absence of regional taxation B. The emperor's personal presence at the mint C. Daily administrative control by Delhi D. A public claim to Mughal legitimacy

Answer: D.

Explanation: Numismatic titlature reveals acknowledged sovereignty and political language.

Trap logic: Material symbols require an implementation limit.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q57. Why could Mughal legitimacy survive military contraction?

Why could Mughal legitimacy survive military contraction?

- A. It remained a recognised language for title, succession, revenue rights and arbitration B. The emperor controlled every provincial treasury C. European companies prohibited local coins D. Regional rulers had no armies

Answer: A.

Explanation: Existing institutions made imperial sanction useful even to autonomous powers.

Trap logic: Symbolic power can have practical political value.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q58. Which answer line is strongest for Aurangzeb's responsibility?

Which answer line is strongest for Aurangzeb's responsibility?

A. His empire had already ceased to exist before his death B. His Deccan and coalition choices aggravated structural strain, but post-1707 institutions and actors determined the trajectory C. He had no role because he died in 1707 D. He alone caused every event through religious policy

Answer: B.

Explanation: Balanced causation distinguishes inherited strain from later mechanisms.

Trap logic: Avoid both exoneration and total blame.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q59. Which statement about 'dark age' is most defensible?

Which statement about 'dark age' is most defensible?

A. It is fully refuted by one prosperous merchant B. It proves culture disappeared C. It captures real imperial and social disruption but fails as an all-region description D. It is a precise statistical category

Answer: C.

Explanation: The period was neither uniform collapse nor uncomplicated regional prosperity.

Trap logic: Use levels, regions and social groups.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q60. Canonical concept check 60

The most useful final verdict on Nadir Shah is:

A. Founder of a permanent Persian Mughal dynasty B. The sole structural cause C. Economically irrelevant D. Decisive in timing and prestige, secondary to deeper causes of decline

Answer: D.

Explanation: His invasion transformed perception and frontier security but depended on prior weakness.

Trap logic: Accelerant and revealer are not euphemisms for no impact.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Q61. Which distinction best captures Mughal decline after 1707?

A. Central enforcement weakened while dynastic legitimacy and administrative vocabulary persisted. B. Trade ceased across India. C. All regional states rejected Mughal forms. D. The dynasty vanished immediately.

Answer: A. Explanation: Central enforcement weakened while dynastic legitimacy and administrative vocabulary persisted.

Q62. What did the Sayyid Brothers' kingmaking primarily demonstrate?

A. A fixed law of primogeniture worked. B. Court coalitions could control accession without becoming emperors themselves. C. Nadir Shah ruled Delhi. D. Jagirs became private estates.

Answer: B. Explanation: Court coalitions could control accession without becoming emperors themselves.

Q63. Why is a high jama not proof of a strong imperial treasury?

A. It abolished local intermediaries. B. It recorded military victories. C. Jama was an assessed claim that could exceed realised hasil. D. It measured coinage only.

Answer: C. Explanation: Jama was an assessed claim that could exceed realised hasil.

Q64. How should Aurangzeb's Deccan wars be used in explanation?

A. As an event after Nadir Shah. B. As proof that provinces had no agency. C. As the sole cause of all later decline. D. As an inherited fiscal-military strain within a wider causal interaction.

Answer: D. Explanation: As an inherited fiscal-military strain within a wider causal interaction.

Q65. Which inference from provincial autonomy is safest?

A. Governors could retain Mughal symbols while controlling practical revenue and patronage. B. Every province became a modern nation-state. C. Coinage proves direct Delhi taxation. D. All governors stopped using imperial titles.

Answer: A. Explanation: Governors could retain Mughal symbols while controlling practical revenue and patronage.

Q66. What does Nadir Shah's victory at Karnal most directly reveal?

A. Mughal legitimacy disappeared that day. B. Fragmented Mughal command was vulnerable to a coordinated invading force. C. The invasion caused every earlier fiscal strain. D. Persia annexed the Gangetic plain.

Answer: B. Explanation: Fragmented Mughal command was vulnerable to a coordinated invading force.

Q67. Which actor belongs to the agrarian-regional feedback rather than only court politics?

A. Only foreign merchants. B. A single chronicler's adjective. C. Zamindars negotiating, resisting or withholding cooperation. D. The Peacock Throne as an object.

Answer: C. Explanation: Zamindars negotiating, resisting or withholding cooperation.

Q68. Which claim should be rejected in a core answer?

A. Jagirdari pressure affected service ties. B. Succession wars weakened arbitration. C. Regional assertion had varied routes. D. Aurangzeb alone explains the post-1707 imperial crisis.

Answer: D. Explanation: Aurangzeb alone explains the post-1707 imperial crisis.

Q69. What is be-jagiri?

A. A shortage of sufficiently productive and usable jagirs for claimants. B. A title for the provincial diwan. C. A category of private freehold. D. A Persian invasion route.

Answer: A. Explanation: A shortage of sufficiently productive and usable jagirs for claimants.

Q70. Why should the core chronology stop in the 1740s?

A. Nadir Shah became Mughal emperor. B. Later Durrani invasions and Panipat are consequences or bridges, not this topic's core causal field. C. Mughal institutions ended in 1740. D. Nothing happened after 1740.

Answer: B. Explanation: Later Durrani invasions and Panipat are consequences or bridges, not this topic's core causal field.

Q71. What is the best use of coin and khutba evidence?

A. It makes farmans unnecessary. B. It proves universal prosperity. C. It can show a claim to Mughal legitimacy but not daily administrative obedience. D. It proves a modern national border.

Answer: C. Explanation: It can show a claim to Mughal legitimacy but not daily administrative obedience.

Q72. Which answer structure is most defensible?

A. List only emperor nicknames. B. Equate all regions with Delhi. C. Treat invasion as the lone origin. D. Weigh succession, faction, fiscal-military strain, regional assertion and Nadir's shock together.

Answer: D. Explanation: Weigh succession, faction, fiscal-military strain, regional assertion and Nadir's shock together.

Q73. Why did short jagir tenure create pressure?

A. It could reward rapid extraction over durable local cooperation. B. It made all zamindars royal officials. C. It abolished mansab service. D. It guaranteed higher hasil.

Answer: A. Explanation: It could reward rapid extraction over durable local cooperation.

Q74. What continuity qualified the image of total collapse?

A. Delhi no longer mattered symbolically. B. Regional rulers continued to use Persianate offices, grants and legitimacy idioms. C. All cultural production stopped. D. No rulers maintained armies.

Answer: B. Explanation: Regional rulers continued to use Persianate offices, grants and legitimacy idioms.

Q75. Which wording is safest about 1739 Delhi?

A. It erased all regional economies. B. It permits a fixed casualty total without sources. C. It was a severe prestige and fiscal shock with contested numerical estimates. D. It established permanent Persian rule.

Answer: C. Explanation: It was a severe prestige and fiscal shock with contested numerical estimates.

Q76. What separates faction from ethnicity in this context?

A. Only one group held office. B. Every noble acted only by birthplace. C. Faction ended in 1720. D. Patronage coalitions shifted and cannot be read as permanent ethnic voting blocs.

Answer: D. Explanation: Patronage coalitions shifted and cannot be read as permanent ethnic voting blocs.

Q77. Which factor is an external shock rather than an original internal mechanism?

A. Nadir Shah's 1739 invasion. B. Provincial retention of resources. C. Jagir-realisation mismatch. D. Succession conflict.

Answer: A. Explanation: Nadir Shah's 1739 invasion.

Q78. What did regional assertion do to imperial capacity?

A. It instantly ended symbolic sovereignty. B. It reduced reliable remittance and made central enforcement more difficult. C. It removed all local diversity. D. It guaranteed Company conquest.

Answer: B. Explanation: It reduced reliable remittance and made central enforcement more difficult.

Q79. Which conclusion reflects institutional continuity?

A. Administrative terms vanished in 1707. B. Decline ended all record-keeping. C. Mughal political grammar outlasted Mughal capacity to command it. D. Autonomy required abandoning titles.

Answer: C. Explanation: Mughal political grammar outlasted Mughal capacity to command it.

Q80. What is the final qualified verdict?

A. The century was uniformly empty of order. B. Only personalities explain history. C. The century was uniformly prosperous. D. The 1707-1740s saw declining central capacity and uneven regional reorganisation, not one monocausal collapse.

Answer: D. Explanation: The 1707-1740s saw declining central capacity and uneven regional reorganisation, not one monocausal collapse.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PART II - VERIFIED/ROUTED PYQS WITH SOLUTIONS

PYQ 01 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q48: eighteenth-century successor states

Verified question: With reference to Indian history, which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. The Nizamat of Arcot emerged out of Hyderabad State.
 2. The Mysore Kingdom emerged out of Vijayanagara Empire.
 3. Rohilkhand Kingdom was formed out of the territories occupied by Ahmad Shah Durrani.
- A. 1 only
 - B. 1 and 2 only
 - C. 2 and 3 only
 - D. 3 only

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: B, 1 and 2 only. Confidence: high. The repository routing verifies the question, but a locally readable UPSC key is unavailable.

Solved explanation

- Statement 1 is correct in the conventional successor-state genealogy: Arcot or the Carnatic operated under the Deccan/Hyderabad subordination before its nawabs acquired practical autonomy.
- Statement 2 is correct: the Wodeyar kingdom of Mysore emerged from the political field of the Vijayanagara order.
- Statement 3 is incorrect: Rohilla power in Rohilkhand grew from Afghan military settlement and weakening Mughal authority before Ahmad Shah Durrani's major Indian interventions; Durrani did not create it from his occupied territories.
- Topic significance: the question tests whether eighteenth-century states are traced to their correct imperial or regional predecessor and whether later Afghan intervention is projected backward.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates each statement independently, supplies the political genealogy and marks the unavailable official key rather than presenting an inference as official.

Demand decoding: Treat "PYQ 01 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q48: eighteenth-century successor states" as a statement-level chronology and attribution problem: verify every date, Act/provision, person, organisation, region and causal claim independently, without inventing an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its exact chronology, named evidence, causal logic, counter-position and qualification.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Fix the tested time window; separate event/enactment/commencement; match each actor and provision; eliminate the closest distractor with one named record, treaty, session or regional fact.

How to improve this answer: For “PYQ 01 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q48: eighteenth-century successor states”, add one explicit line showing why the nearest distractor fails on date, legal status, geography, attribution or degree.

PYQ 02 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q45: Mughal administrative hierarchy

Verified question: With reference to medieval India, which one of the following is the correct sequence in ascending order in terms of size?

- A. Paragana - Sarkar - Suba
- B. Sarkar - Paragana - Suba
- C. Suba - Sarkar - Paragana
- D. Paragana - Suba - Sarkar

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: A, Paragana - Sarkar - Suba. Confidence: high.

Solved explanation

- A pargana grouped villages and formed the smaller revenue-administrative unit in this sequence.
- A sarkar grouped parganas.
- A subah was the larger province containing sarkars.
- Topic significance: the hierarchy is the territorial skeleton inherited in 1707. Decline occurred when provincial and local officers appropriated power inside this structure, not because the hierarchy instantly disappeared.

Why this earns marks: It gives the exact ascending order and links the fact to the mechanism of provincial autonomy rather than treating it as isolated recall.

Demand decoding: Treat “PYQ 02 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q45: Mughal administrative hierarchy” as a statement-level chronology and attribution problem: verify every date, Act/provision, person, organisation, region and causal claim independently, without inventing an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its exact chronology, named evidence, causal logic, counter-position and qualification.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Fix the tested time window; separate event/enactment/commencement; match each actor and provision; eliminate the closest distractor with one named record, treaty, session or regional fact.

How to improve this answer: For “PYQ 02 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q45: Mughal administrative hierarchy”, add one explicit line showing why the nearest distractor fails on date, legal status, geography, attribution or degree.

PYQ 03 - 2022 GS-I Mains Q2: Company armies and Indian rulers

Verified adjacent question: Why did the armies of the British East India Company - mostly comprising Indian soldiers - win consistently against the more numerous and better equipped armies of the then Indian rulers? Give reasons. (10 marks, 150 words)

Routing note: The direct owner is Modern History Topic 05. It is included here only as a verified bounded consequence because the 1707-1740s transition created a competitive multi-state field; it did not itself make Company victory inevitable.

Model answer

The Company's victories arose less from the ethnicity of its soldiers than from the organisation that converted them into a reliable fiscal-military force. Indian rulers inherited capable cavalry, artillery and revenue systems, but their armies were often composite contingents tied to chiefs. The Mughal experience at **Karnal (1739)** shows how divided command could neutralise numerical strength; Maratha confederate chiefs and successor states later faced similar coordination problems, though in different forms.

By contrast, the Company combined regular drill, standardised infantry-artillery coordination and promotion within a single command. Its coastal bases and British naval network sustained supply, while London and Indian merchant credit financed long campaigns. Political intelligence, diplomacy and alliances divided opponents. After **Plassey (1757)** and especially the **Diwani (1765)**, Bengal revenue increasingly funded further war.

Yet victory was contingent: Mysore, Marathas and Sikhs repeatedly imposed serious reverses. The decisive advantage was a cumulative organisation-credit-revenue system, not inherent European bravery or Indian military incapacity.

Why this earns marks: It answers "why" through six mechanisms, uses Karnal only as bounded background, names Plassey and Diwani as later fiscal turning points, and qualifies inevitability with Indian resistance.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ 03 - 2022 GS-I Mains Q2: Company armies and Indian rulers", coverage of every clause, chronological-causal analysis, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its exact chronology, named evidence, causal logic, counter-position and qualification.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named Acts, events, organisations, regions, primary records or scholarly positions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ 03 - 2022 GS-I Mains Q2: Company armies and Indian rulers", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named primary/official record or attributed scholarly interpretation and state exactly what it cannot prove.

PYQ coverage conclusion

The audited repository routes one directly relevant eighteenth-century successor-state Prelims question and one administrative-inheritance question. No direct GS-I Mains question confined to Mughal decline in 1707-1740s appears in the audited 2018-2025 route; the verified 2022 Company-armies question is therefore included only as an explicitly bounded bridge. No History Optional question is invented.

PART IV - ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

Mains 10M-1 - Distinguish between decline, decentralisation and regionalisation in the Mughal context after 1707.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 150 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

The terms identify different levels of the same transition. **Decline** refers to the loss of enforceable authority at Delhi: repeated succession struggles, the Sayyids' deposition of Farrukhsiyar in 1719 and divided command at Karnal in 1739 show that the emperor could no longer arbitrate elites or defend the frontier.

Decentralisation describes the movement of revenue and appointment power from the centre to provinces. Murshid Quli Khan in Bengal, Saadat Khan in Awadh and Nizam-ul-Mulk in Hyderabad retained Mughal offices but made collection, military command and succession increasingly regional.

Regionalisation goes further: provincial governors, zamindars, bankers and military groups formed durable political arenas. Bengal's large zamindars and Jagat Seth finance, Maratha chauth networks, and Jat-Sikh mobilisation reveal new coalitions below Delhi.

The processes overlapped but were not identical. Coin, khutba, Persian chancery and imperial confirmation survived, so political force shifted before Mughal legitimacy disappeared. The period was therefore decline at the centre, decentralisation of functions and uneven regionalisation of power.

Why this earns marks: It defines all three terms, supplies three distinct evidence clusters, shows overlap without collapsing categories and ends with a precise two-level verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Mains 10M-1 - Distinguish between decline, decentralisation and regionalisation in the...", coverage of every clause, chronological-causal analysis, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its exact chronology, named evidence, causal logic, counter-position and qualification.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named Acts, events, organisations, regions, primary records or scholarly positions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 10M-1 - Distinguish between decline, decentralisation and regionalisation in the...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named primary/official record or attributed scholarly interpretation and state exactly what it cannot prove.

Mains 10M-2 - Were the Sayyid Brothers merely destroyers of Mughal authority? Examine.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 150 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

The Sayyid Brothers were both products and accelerants of the Mughal crisis, not merely destroyers. Abdullah Khan and Husain Ali raised Farrukhsiyar in 1713 because succession already depended on armed noble coalitions. Their conflict with him concerned the imperial seal, appointments, jagirs and Deccan resources - the substance of sovereignty.

They also attempted repair. Satish Chandra records their abolition of jizya and pilgrim taxes, conciliation of Jai Singh, Ajit Singh and Churaman, and the 1718-19 settlement that exchanged recognition of Shahu's fiscal claims for Maratha support. These were efforts to widen the ruling coalition.

Yet their deposition and killing of Farrukhsiyar in 1719 made Timurid monarchy visibly dependent on kingmakers. Rapid enthronements and patronage promises intensified jagir factionalism; opponents could then rally around dynasty, old nobility and religion. Husain Ali's assassination and Abdullah's defeat in 1720 ended their power, not the underlying crisis.

Thus the Sayyids administered creatively under structural pressure, but their coercive kingmaking deepened the loss of monarchical authority.

Why this earns marks: It directly tests the word 'merely', balances policies against consequences, names offices, rulers and settlements, and distinguishes symptom from agency.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Mains 10M-2 - Were the Sayyid Brothers merely destroyers of Mughal authority? Examine.”, coverage of every clause, chronological-causal analysis, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its exact chronology, named evidence, causal logic, counter-position and qualification.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named Acts, events, organisations, regions, primary records or scholarly positions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 10M-2 - Were the Sayyid Brothers merely destroyers of Mughal authority? Examine.”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named primary/official record or attributed scholarly interpretation and state exactly what it cannot prove.

Mains 10M-3 - Explain why the invasion of Nadir Shah was an exposure rather than the origin of Mughal decline.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 150 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

Nadir Shah's invasion was possible because the imperial system had already weakened. Before 1739, Farrukhsiyar had been deposed by noble kingmakers; Nizam-ul-Mulk had converted Deccan office into Hyderabad autonomy in 1724; Bengal and Awadh retained revenue; and mansabdars often failed to maintain full contingents because jagir yields and cash were unreliable.

The frontier reproduced this failure. Delhi did not turn Nadir's repeated embassies or the fall of Qandahar and Kabul into timely reinforcement. At **Karnal, 24 February 1739**, Muhammad Shah's leading nobles disputed command. Saadat Khan engaged without an integrated plan, Khan-i-Dauran was mortally wounded, and Nadir's unified mobile force prevailed.

The invasion nevertheless accelerated decline. Delhi suffered massacre and plunder; the emperor ceded territories west of the Indus; prestige collapsed; and regional actors saw that the centre could not protect itself. But Muhammad Shah remained emperor, Delhi recovered commercial life and Mughal legitimacy survived.

Karnal was therefore an X-ray of a prior fiscal-command crisis and a severe new blow, not its original disease.

Why this earns marks: It proves pre-existing weakness with four named units, explains Karnal's mechanism, gives real consequences and avoids minimising the invasion.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on "Mains 10M-3 - Explain why the invasion of Nadir Shah was an exposure rather than the origin...", coverage of every clause, chronological-causal analysis, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its exact chronology, named evidence, causal logic, counter-position and qualification.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named Acts, events, organisations, regions, primary records or scholarly positions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 10M-3 - Explain why the invasion of Nadir Shah was an exposure rather than the origin...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named primary/official record or attributed scholarly interpretation and state exactly what it cannot prove.

Mains 15M-1 - Critically examine the jagirdari-agrarian crisis as an explanation of Mughal decline.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 250 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

The jagirdari-agrarian thesis is powerful because it links elite politics, rural extraction and military weakness, but it must be regionally qualified.

Institutional mechanism: Satish Chandra argues that mansab and salary claims outgrew dependable assignments. *Be-jagiri*, competition for productive jagirs and the diversion of khalisa weakened the centre's cash. The **jama-hasil** gap meant that paper assessment did not equal realised revenue.

Rural transmission: Frequent transfer encouraged short-term extraction. Bipan Chandra notes the spread of **ijara**, under which contractors promised a fixed sum and sought profit from cultivators. Irfan Habib connects high surplus demand to peasant flight, arrears and zamindar-led Jat, Sikh and other resistance.

Military consequence: Nobles with inadequate income did not maintain full contingents. Thus fiscal weakness reduced coercion; weaker coercion further reduced collection. Court parties then recruited followers by promising ranks and jagirs, as in the Farrukhsiyar-Sayyid conflict.

Qualifications: John F. Richards asks whether Deccan revenues and khalisa choices made part of the scarcity policy-produced. Muzaffar Alam and C.A. Bayly point to agrarian growth, monetisation, bankers and regional states, showing that resources were redistributed rather than universally destroyed. Bengal's strong collection under Murshid Quli Khan is counter-evidence to an all-India production collapse, although it could burden smaller zamindars and peasants.

Therefore the crisis is best treated as a variable mechanism: assignment, extraction and service diverged, but the degree and social outcome differed across regions.

Why this earns marks: It defines the mechanism, uses Chandra, Habib, Richards and revisionist counter-evidence, connects fiscal and military outcomes and gives a qualified rather than absolute verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **critically examine** requires a direct position on "Mains 15M-1 - Critically examine the jagirdari-agrarian crisis as an explanation of Mughal...", coverage of every clause, chronological-causal analysis, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its exact chronology, named evidence, causal logic, counter-position and qualification.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named Acts, events, organisations, regions, primary records or scholarly positions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 15M-1 - Critically examine the jagirdari-agrarian crisis as an explanation of Mughal...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named primary/official record or attributed scholarly interpretation and state exactly what it cannot prove.

Mains 15M-2 - The Mughal successor states represented continuity in form and autonomy in substance. Discuss with reference to Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 250 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad did not emerge through one clean declaration of independence. They converted Mughal provincial office into hereditary regional authority while preserving the imperial idiom.

Bengal: Murshid Quli Khan, confirmed governor in 1717, tightened survey and collection through powerful zamindars, transferred troublesome jagirdars and relied on merchant-bankers. Remittance and formal allegiance initially continued, but appointments and dynastic succession became provincial. The Jagat Seth house's later role in treasury and mint shows a regional fiscal coalition.

Awadh: Saadat Khan, appointed in 1722, subdued local rajas and expanded provincial command. Yet he still sought imperial office. Safdar Jung's succession after 1739-40 required gifts and confirmation, proving that autonomy and Timurid sanction reinforced each other.

Hyderabad: Nizam-ul-Mulk left the wizarat and defeated Mubariz Khan in 1724. He conducted war, appointment and revenue regionally, while coins, khutba and mansab vocabulary retained Muhammad Shah's sovereignty. Deccan merchants, revenue intermediaries and military elites gave the state its distinct base.

The states also differed: Bengal was a rich agrarian-commercial province, Awadh a middle-Ganga military-revenue arena and Hyderabad a multi-centred Deccan polity constrained by Marathas and local chiefs.

Thus Mughal administrative forms reduced the cost of regional state-building, while control over revenue and force moved decisively away from Delhi.

Why this earns marks: It compares three states through the same analytical headings, supplies named fiscal and legitimacy evidence, states regional differences and answers both continuity and autonomy.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "Mains 15M-2 - The Mughal successor states represented continuity in form and autonomy in...", coverage of every clause, chronological-causal analysis, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its exact chronology, named evidence, causal logic, counter-position and qualification.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named Acts, events, organisations, regions, primary records or scholarly positions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 15M-2 - The Mughal successor states represented continuity in form and autonomy in...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named primary/official record or attributed scholarly interpretation and state exactly what it cannot prove.

Mains 15M-3 - How far was Aurangzeb responsible for the decline of the Mughal Empire?

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 250 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

Aurangzeb was substantially responsible for intensifying the empire's constraints, but he cannot be made the single cause of a decline worked out after 1707.

Real responsibility: The long Deccan commitment absorbed treasury and troops, added difficult territories and failed to extinguish Maratha mobility. Incorporating Deccani and Maratha entrants increased claims on mansabs and jagirs. The emperor's prolonged southern presence weakened supervision of the north and northwest. Conflict over Marwar damaged a Rajput alliance central to Mughal power; jizya and some temple policies narrowed legitimacy in places.

Necessary qualification: Bipan Chandra notes that administration, army and dynastic prestige remained substantial at Aurangzeb's death. Religious measures were reversed: Bahadur Shah and later the Sayyids restored broad accommodation, while Hindu and Muslim nobles repeatedly allied across faith for office and revenue.

Post-1707 mechanisms: Succession wars killed commanders and made noble coalitions decisive. The Sayyids deposed Farrukhsiyar; Nizam-ul-Mulk regionalised Deccan power; jagir and agrarian pressures weakened contingents; Bengal and Awadh retained revenue; and Muhammad Shah's nobles failed to coordinate at Karnal.

Jadunath Sarkar's ruler-centred reading therefore identifies important agency but becomes inadequate when communal or moral blame replaces institutional evidence. Satish Chandra's jagirdari-Deccan synthesis better explains transmission.

Aurangzeb aggravated the inheritance; later fiscal, political and regional choices converted strain into systemic decline.

Why this earns marks: It answers 'how far' with concession, qualification and ranking; uses Deccan, Rajput, jizya, Sayyids, successor states and Karnal; and attributes historiography accurately.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Mains 15M-3 - How far was Aurangzeb responsible for the decline of the Mughal Empire?”, coverage of every clause, chronological-causal analysis, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its exact chronology, named evidence, causal logic, counter-position and qualification.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named Acts, events, organisations, regions, primary records or scholarly positions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 15M-3 - How far was Aurangzeb responsible for the decline of the Mughal Empire?”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named primary/official record or attributed scholarly interpretation and state exactly what it cannot prove.

Mains 20M-1 - Why did Mughal central authority decline between 1707 and the 1740s? Present a weighted multi-causal explanation.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 350 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

Mughal central authority declined because the fiscal-military contract that joined emperor, nobility, province and countryside ceased to reproduce revenue, service and obedience. Weak rulers and invasion mattered, but they operated through a deeper interactive crisis.

1. Inherited over-extension: Aurangzeb left a formidable empire, yet the long Deccan war had tied down forces, complicated jagir allocation and failed to eliminate Maratha mobility. Rajput and Punjab difficulties and weakened northwest attention added strain. This was a difficult inheritance, not inevitable collapse.

2. Succession and arbitration: With no fixed succession rule, Jajau in 1707 and the contests after Bahadur Shah's death consumed soldiers and made the throne dependent on noble coalitions. Farrukhsiyar's deposition in 1719 showed that kingmakers could control monarchy; rapid enthronements weakened dynastic awe.

3. Jagirdari-fiscal mechanism: Satish Chandra's *be-jagiri* thesis links a growing body of claimants to inadequate or low-yield assignments. Jama exceeded hasil, khalisa was granted away and frequent transfer promoted short-term extraction. Under ijara, contractors pressed cultivators for profit. Nobles in arrears maintained incomplete contingents.

4. Agrarian and regional feedback: Irfan Habib connects extraction to peasant and zamindar resistance. Jats, Sikhs, Bundelas and local chiefs withheld revenue and fortified power. Revisionist evidence adds that agrarian growth, bankers and monetisation could strengthen regions: Murshid Quli Khan's Bengal was fiscally vigorous even as Delhi lost remittance.

5. Provincial and Maratha reordering: Saadat Khan's Awadh and Nizam-ul-Mulk's Hyderabad converted office into autonomy while retaining imperial legitimacy. Maratha chauth and sardeshmukhi moved from contested exaction to imperial bargaining in 1718-19 and wider expansion under Baji Rao.

6. Military-command failure: The army retained artillery and numbers, but paper mansabs, arrears, slow logistics and factional command reduced usable strength. At Karnal in 1739, divided Mughal action faced Nadir's integrated mobility and fire discipline.

7. External shock: Nadir's victory, the Delhi massacre, plunder and loss west of the Indus devastated prestige and frontier security. Yet regional autonomy and fiscal weakness clearly predated him.

The causal order is therefore weighted: fiscal-military and political structures formed the core; rural and regional movements amplified them; military underperformance transmitted them; Nadir determined the dramatic timing and visibility of collapse. Mughal legitimacy and institutions survived, so the outcome was central decline with uneven regional transition, not instant disappearance.

Why this earns marks: It gives a ranked mechanism rather than a list, uses more than eight named evidence units, separates inherited strain from post-1707 transmission, integrates revisionist counter-evidence and ends with a level-specific verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Mains 20M-1 - Why did Mughal central authority decline between 1707 and the 1740s? Present...", coverage of every clause, chronological-causal analysis, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its exact chronology, named evidence, causal logic, counter-position and qualification.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named Acts, events, organisations, regions, primary records or scholarly positions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 20M-1 - Why did Mughal central authority decline between 1707 and the 1740s? Present...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named primary/official record or attributed scholarly interpretation and state exactly what it cannot prove.

Mains 20M-2 - Was the eighteenth century in India a 'dark age' of decline or an age of regional transformation? Critically discuss with reference to 1707-1740s.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 350 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

Neither label is sufficient alone. The period was a darkening of Mughal central fiscal-military capacity and, simultaneously, an uneven transformation of political and economic power toward regions.

Evidence for decline: Succession contests after 1707 destroyed continuity and empowered factions. Farrukhsiyar's deposition by the Sayyids in 1719 eroded monarchical prestige. Jagir competition, jama-hasil gaps and ijara shifted pressure toward cultivators; Jat, Sikh and zamindar resistance disrupted revenue. Provincial remittance weakened, mansabdars under-maintained contingents and Nadir Shah's victory at Karnal in 1739 culminated in massacre, plunder and frontier loss.

Older narratives associated with Jadunath Sarkar read these developments through Aurangzeb, weak successors and moral-political decay. They preserve chronology and agency but risk treating court conduct and religious policy as complete causation.

Evidence for transformation: Bengal under Murshid Quli Khan created a strong revenue order supported by large zamindars and bankers. Saadat Khan's Awadh and Nizam-ul-Mulk's Hyderabad retained Mughal titles, coins, khutba and administration while regionalising force and revenue. Maratha networks converted chauth and sardeshmukhi into a wide political system; Jats and Sikhs built durable local mobilisation.

Muzaffar Alam and C.A. Bayly therefore stress decentralisation, regional politics, credit and "portfolio" resources. Cultural evidence strengthens the case: Dargah Quli Khan's Delhi, Muhammad Shah's music and painting, and the movement of Persianate forms to regional courts contradict total civilisational collapse. Satish Chandra even cautions that the famous economic effect of Nadir's booty is often overstated.

Social and regional qualification: Regional vitality could rest on coercive collection. Murshid Quli's efficient Bengal disadvantaged smaller zamindars; warfare and revenue farming exposed peasants and artisans. Delhi's recovery cannot represent every devastated corridor.

The best synthesis is a two-level history: the imperial centre declined catastrophically, while political authority, commerce and culture were reorganised through regions with unequal benefits and costs. "Transition" is the broader category; "decline" remains indispensable for Delhi's lost capacity.

Why this earns marks: It constructs and tests both sides with political, fiscal, regional, economic and cultural evidence; names historiographical positions; adds social costs; and delivers a non-evasive critical verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "Mains 20M-2 - Was the eighteenth century in India a 'dark age' of decline or an age of...", coverage of every clause, chronological-causal analysis, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its exact chronology, named evidence, causal logic, counter-position and qualification.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named Acts, events, organisations, regions, primary records or scholarly positions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 20M-2 - Was the eighteenth century in India a 'dark age' of decline or an age of...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named primary/official record or attributed scholarly interpretation and state exactly what it cannot prove.

Mains 20M-3 - Analyse the relationship between military weakness, regional autonomy and the survival of Mughal legitimacy in the early eighteenth century.

Directive and limit: Answer in approximately 350 words. Use a direct thesis, evidence-linked analysis, one qualification and a reasoned verdict.

Model answer

The apparent paradox of the early eighteenth century is that Mughal military enforcement contracted while Mughal legitimacy remained the preferred language of new power. The two developments were connected.

Military weakness: The mansab system mobilised composite noble contingents, not one uniformly drilled standing army. Jagir arrears and weak inspection meant that sanctioned rank exceeded deployable troops. Heavy artillery, large camps and capable cavalry remained, but factional commanders disputed precedence and plan. At Karnal in 1739, Saadat Khan's uncoordinated engagement, Khan-i-Dauran's fatal intervention and Nizam-ul-Mulk's constrained role allowed Nadir Shah's unified mobile force to defeat a larger host.

Regional autonomy as response: Where Delhi could not guarantee assignment, protection or arbitration, powerful office-holders internalised resources. Murshid Quli Khan made Bengal's revenue administration provincial; Saadat Khan subdued Awadh's chiefs; Nizam-ul-Mulk transformed the Deccan viceroyalty into Hyderabad after 1724. Marathas extracted chauth and sardeshmukhi, while Jats, Sikhs and zamindars built armed local networks. Military labour and finance followed reliable regional patrons.

Why legitimacy survived: None of these actors operated in an institutional vacuum. The Timurid emperor could still grant mansabs, titles, farmans and sanads that rival claimants recognised. Hyderabad retained coin and khutba in the emperor's name; Safdar Jung sought confirmation in Awadh; Maratha leaders sought imperial documentary recognition; the English Company relied on Farrukhsiyar's 1717 farman.

Significance: Mughal forms reduced the legitimacy cost of decentralisation. A governor could exercise independent war and taxation while presenting succession as lawful continuity. Control of the emperor therefore remained valuable even after he lost provincial command.

Limit: Symbols were not mere fiction, but neither did they restore cash or battlefield coordination. Their practical effect depended on recognition by nobles, zamindars, merchants and rival states.

Thus military weakness shifted protection and patronage to regions, while the shared Mughal administrative-cultural order enabled that shift to occur without an immediate formal rupture. Force regionalised faster than legitimacy.

Why this earns marks: It answers the relationship rather than three separate themes, uses Karnal, three successor states, Marathas and documentary/numismatic evidence, and distinguishes practical symbolic power from direct control.

Demand decoding: The directive **analyse** requires a direct position on "Mains 20M-3 - Analyse the relationship between military weakness, regional autonomy and the...", coverage of every clause, chronological-causal analysis, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its exact chronology, named evidence, causal logic, counter-position and qualification.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named Acts, events, organisations, regions, primary records or scholarly positions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 20M-3 - Analyse the relationship between military weakness, regional autonomy and the...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named primary/official record or attributed scholarly interpretation and state exactly what it cannot prove.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707-1740s) - ADVANCED

Subject: History (Modern India) · **Tier:** Advanced (deeper understanding) · **GS Paper:** GS-I (also Prelims).
Grounded in: Bipin Chandra, *Modern India* (Ch. I), cross-checked against Sekhar Bandyopadhyay, *From Plassey to Partition* - with the historiographical debate on eighteenth-century decline. **FACT:** = from source book · **ANALYSIS:** = inference / standard knowledge · **CURRENT:** = current affairs. *Companion:* basic/01_Decline-of-the-Mughal-Empire.md. *Chronology spine:* 00_Master-Chronology.md.

Mini-timeline

Date	Event
FACT: 1707	Aurangzeb dies at Ahmadnagar; succession war among his sons
FACT: 1707-12	Bahadur Shah I (Shah Alam I) - conciliation with Rajputs/Marathas/Sikhs
FACT: 1713-19	Farrukhsiyar; Sayyid Brothers dominate; 1717 farman to the English Company
FACT: 1719	Four puppet emperors in one year; Muhammad Shah enthroned
FACT: 1724	Nizam-ul-Mulk quits the wazirat -> founds Hyderabad ; provinces autonomous
FACT: 1739	Karnal ; Nadir Shah sacks Delhi (Peacock Throne, Kohinoor)
FACT: 1748-61	Abdali's invasions; Mughal power reduced to Delhi environs

1. Snapshot & core idea

Deeper - the debate over why the empire declined.

- FACT: Bipin Chandra frames decline as **structural**, not merely a matter of "bad kings": the **jagirdari and agrarian crisis** was central. The number of nobles (mansabdars) and their claims outran the supply of revenue-yielding **jagirs**, producing a scramble (*be-jagiri*) that turned the nobility inward against itself and against the peasantry.
- ANALYSIS: Historiography (context to know): **Satish Chandra** located the crisis in the jagirdari-agrarian system; **Irfan Habib** stressed the **agrarian crisis** (over-exploitation of peasants driving revolts); the **Aligarh school** emphasised systemic economic strain, while a **regional/"revisionist" view** (Muzaffar Alam, C.A. Bayly) reframed 18th-century "decline" as a **shift of power and prosperity to the regions**, not universal collapse.
- FACT: The nobility split into **ethnic-factional blocs** - Turani, Irani, Afghan and Hindustani (Indian-born) - whose rivalries paralysed the centre; the **Sayyid Brothers** (Hindustani faction) epitomised how nobles, not emperors, now decided the throne.

Deeper - Aurangzeb's Deccan and the fiscal over-stretch.

- FACT: Aurangzeb's prolonged **Deccan campaigns** over-extended the empire militarily and financially and failed to extinguish Maratha resistance. ANALYSIS: The relative importance of Rajput conflict and religious policy remains debated and should not be used as a single-cause explanation.
- FACT: Under weak successors the **provincial governors** (Bengal under Murshid Quli Khan, Awadh under Saadat Khan, Hyderabad under the Nizam) founded effectively **hereditary, autonomous states** while still coining money and reading the *khutba* in the emperor's name - a legal fiction of unity over a real fragmentation.

2. Key classification / data

Interpretation	Emphasis	Associated with
FACT: Jagirdari crisis	Nobles > available jagirs (<i>be-jagiri</i>); factionalism	Satish Chandra / Bipin Chandra
ANALYSIS: Agrarian crisis	Over-taxation -> zamindar/peasant revolts	Irfan Habib (Aligarh)
ANALYSIS: Cultural/personal decline thesis	Courtly morality, rulers' character or religious policy	Older interpretation; insufficient without fiscal, agrarian and regional evidence
ANALYSIS: Regional "revisionist" view	18th c. = redistribution of power to regions, not collapse	Muzaffar Alam, C.A. Bayly
FACT: Personal/successor factor	Weak rulers, wars of succession, king-making nobles	Bipin Chandra

3. Study links

Study link: FACT: Successor states (Bengal, Awadh, Hyderabad, Marathas, Sikhs, Jats) -> advanced/02. **Study link:** ANALYSIS: The **1717 farman** to the English Company -> advanced/03 (European settlements) & advanced/04 (Bengal conquest). **Study link:** ANALYSIS: Compare jagirdari crisis with the **Medieval** analysis -> Medieval-Indian-History/advanced/25.

4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)

- FACT: **1717 farman** (Farrukhsiyar) gave the English Company duty-free trade in Bengal - a major cause of later friction.
- FACT: **Murshid Quli Khan** (Bengal), **Saadat Khan/Burhan-ul-Mulk** (Awadh), **Nizam-ul-Mulk Asaf Jah** (Hyderabad, 1724) founded autonomous provincial dynasties.
- FACT: **Karnal (1739)** - Nadir Shah's victory; Delhi sacked; **Peacock Throne & Kohinoor** taken.
- FACT: **Sayyid Brothers** = Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali (the "king-makers").
- ANALYSIS: Historiographic labels to deploy: **jagirdari crisis** (Satish Chandra), **agrarian crisis** (Irfan Habib), **regional revisionism** (Alam/Bayly).

5. UPSC Traps

MEMORY: Trap: Distinguish "**decline of the empire**" (central authority) from "**decline of the economy/regions.**" The revisionist point is that many *regions prospered* even as the *centre* collapsed.

- WRONG: 18th-century India was uniformly decadent and stagnant. -> Regional economies and states (Bengal, Awadh, Marathas) were often **vibrant**; "decline" was of the *centre*.
- WRONG: The jagirdari crisis was simply corruption. -> It was a **structural mismatch** between the number of claimants and revenue-yielding assignments.
- WRONG: Provincial governors declared full independence. -> They kept the **legal fiction** of Mughal sovereignty (coins/khutba in the emperor's name).
- WRONG: Nadir Shah's and Abdali's invasions *caused* the decline. -> They **accelerated and exposed** a decline that was already structural.

6. CURRENT: Current link

- ANALYSIS: **Cultural repatriation & the Kohinoor debate.** The Kohinoor (looted by Nadir Shah in 1739, later British crown jewel) and the Peacock Throne recur in India's periodic demands for the return of looted heritage. Relevance: an 18th-century plunder story that feeds present GS-2 cultural-diplomacy and GS-1 art-&-culture debates. (*Escalate to CURRENT: when tied to a specific verified news peg.*)

7. Mains angles

- ANALYSIS: "The eighteenth century was less a 'dark age' of decline than an age of political decentralisation and regional reordering." Critically discuss with reference to the historiographical debate.
- ANALYSIS: Examine the **jagirdari-agrarian crisis** as the structural core of Mughal decline, distinguishing it from personal and external factors.
- ANALYSIS: How did the autonomy of the successor states create both the opportunity and the instruments for **British expansion**?

□ Historiography note (PYQ-gap)

ANALYSIS: UPSC (GS-1 & History optional) repeatedly probes the **"eighteenth-century debate."** Be ready to name and contrast: **Jadunath Sarkar** (moral/character decline, "Aurangzeb's religious policy"), **Satish Chandra** (jagirdari crisis), **Irfan Habib** (agrarian crisis), and the **revisionists Muzaffar Alam & C.A. Bayly** (regional continuity/prosperity). This "why did the Mughal Empire decline?" framework is a high-yield analytical template.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

FINAL CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES - PLACED LAST

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/12: Scope: decline of command, not disappearance

1707 -> imperial command weakens; dynasty, titles and Persianate grammar endure
CORE WINDOW -> succession, factions, jagirs, regions and Nadir Shah to the 1740s
NOT THE CLAIM -> instant 1707 collapse, universal Indian decline or Company inevitability
ANSWER RULE -> distinguish enforceable authority from symbolic legitimacy.
MUST REMEMBER: Aurangzeb's death in 1707 begins the core sequence; succession wars, factional competition, jagirdari-fiscal stress, regional assertion and Nadir Shah's 1739 invasion interacted.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/12: Chronology from Aurangzeb to the 1740s

1707 Aurangzeb dies -> Bahadur Shah I 1707-12 -> Jahandar Shah 1712-13
1713 Farrukhsiyar rises with Sayyid support -> 1719 deposition and enthronements
1720 Sayyids fall -> 1724 Nizam's Hyderabad autonomy -> 1739 Karnal and Delhi
1740s -> regional bargaining and frontier pressure; later Durrani/Panipat stay bounded.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/12: Succession instability: throne becomes a prize

NO FIXED PRIMOGENITURE -> princes mobilise households and noble clients
SUCCESSION WAR -> victory reallocates mansab, jagir and office
REPEATED CONTEST -> emperor cannot credibly arbitrate elite competition
RESULT -> political transmission fails; it is a mechanism, not a lone cause.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/12: Factions and the Sayyid moment

TURANI / IRANI / AFGHAN / HINDUSTANI -> shifting patronage formations
FARRUKHSIYAR 1713 -> Sayyid Brothers supply military-political support
1719 -> kingmaking exposes the throne's dependence on coalition control
1720 -> Sayyids removed; factional politics survives the two individuals.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/12: Jagirdari vocabulary prevents category errors

JAGIR -> transferable revenue assignment, not private landownership
JAMA -> assessed claim | HASIL -> realised collection
PAIBAQI -> reserve assignable pool | BE-JAGIRI -> usable jagir shortage
TRAP -> nominal assessment never automatically measures treasury cash or welfare.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/12: Fiscal-military feedback loop

MORE CLAIMANTS + WEAK PAIBAQI -> scramble for productive jagirs
SHORT TENURE / EXTRACTION -> resistance, evasion, flight or negotiation
LOWER HASIL -> unpaid contingents and weaker imperial service
WEAKER CONTROL -> regional retention of revenue -> still lower central capacity.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/12: Aurangzeb's legacy: a weighted background

DECCAN WAR -> garrisons, transport, remounts and unresolved Maratha challenge
ANNEXATIONS -> territory and claims grow faster than reliable realisation
NORTH ABSENCE -> strains of supervision and arbitration
QUALIFY -> legacy mattered, but Aurangzeb alone cannot explain post-1707 factions or regions.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/12: Agrarian and regional assertion

REVENUE PRESSURE -> zamindars, peasants and intermediaries bargain or resist
GOVERNORS + BANKERS + ARMED FOLLOWINGS -> provincial resource control
MARATHA / SIKH / JAT mobilisation -> distinct political routes, not one rebellion
RESULT -> Delhi's weakening and regional state-making reinforce each other.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/12: Successor-state spectrum

BENGAL -> Murshid Quli Khan | AWADH -> Saadat Khan | HYDERABAD -> Nizam-ul-Mulk
IMPERIAL OFFICE -> local revenue, army and patronage become durable
COIN / KHUTBA / TITLE -> formal Mughal legitimacy may remain useful
TRAP -> autonomy in substance does not require a modern declaration of independence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/12: Nadir Shah: shock exposes a prior crisis

FRONTIER WEAKNESS + Persian military capacity -> invasion opportunity
KARNAL, 24 FEBRUARY 1739 -> fragmented command loses to unified command
DELHI -> sack, treasury loss and prestige shock; Muhammad Shah remains emperor
VERDICT -> accelerant and revealer, not the original cause of decline.
CLOSE DISTINCTION: Decline of enforceable central command did not mean instant state collapse, civilisational decline or disappearance of Mughal titles, revenue forms and Persianate legitimacy.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/12: Institutional continuity after contraction

EMPEROR / FARMAN / SANAD -> symbolic arbitration and legal vocabulary
COIN + KHUTBA -> layered legitimacy | PERSIAN CHANCERY -> portable administration
MANSAB / DIWAN / ZAMINDAR -> institutions repurposed in regional arenas
RULE -> continuity of form coexists with change in who commands resources.
EVIDENCE LIMIT: Satish Chandra's jagirdari analysis, regional-state evidence and court chronicles must be compared; no single-ruler or British-inevitability thesis is sufficient.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/12: Topic 01 answer spine

OPEN -> central fiscal-military command declined inside a continuing political culture
EXPLAIN -> succession + faction + jagir-agrarian strain + regional assertion
WEIGH -> Deccan legacy matters; reject Aurangzeb-only monocausality
TEST -> Nadir 1739 exposes weakness; continuity and regional variation qualify conclusion
CLOSE -> stop core chronology in the 1740s.